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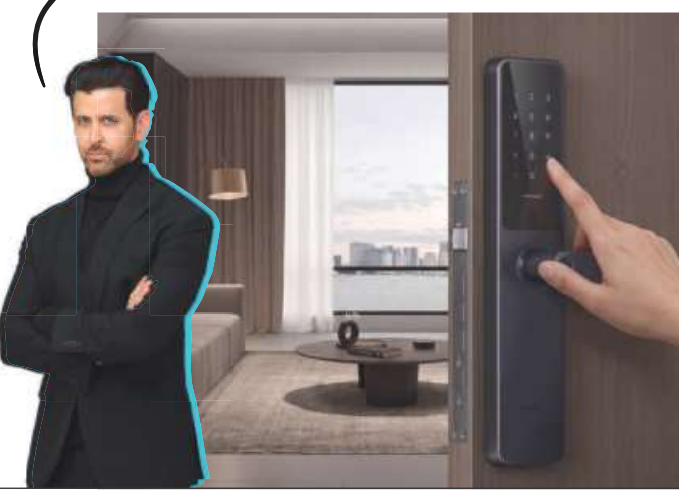
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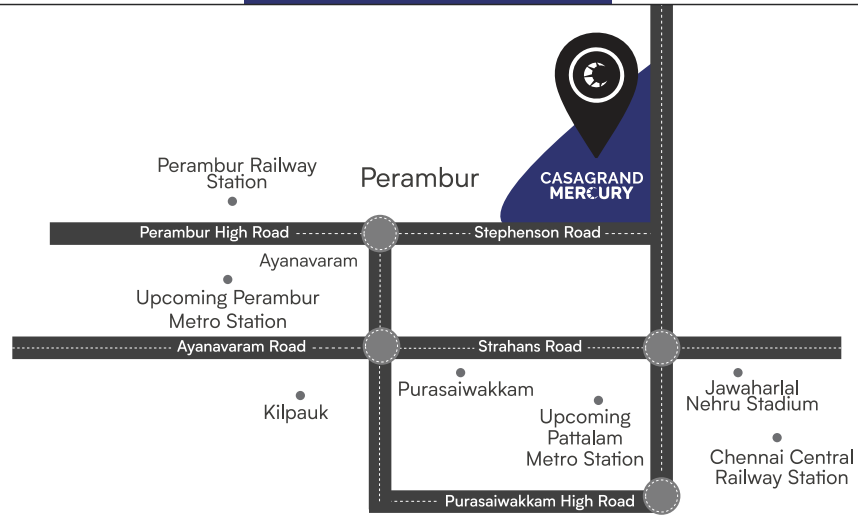


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Kilpauk	₹ 19,000/sft.
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LOCATION MAP





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மருத்துவமனை
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விழுக்காடு கல்விக்கட்டண சலுகை.

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பேர் பயனடைகின்றனர்.

- வேலம்மாள் மருத்துவக்கல்லூரி மருத்துவமனையானது, தமிழகத்திலேயே 2100 படுக்கைகளுடன் அமைக்கப்பட்டுள்ள ஒரே மருத்துவக்கல்லூரி மருத்துவமனை.
- 400க்கும் மேற்பட்ட மருத்துவர்கள் 850க்கும் மேற்பட்ட செவிலியர்கள், டெக்னீசியன்கள், 1550க்கும் மேற்பட்ட மருத்துவப் பணியாளர்கள் என மொத்தம் 2800 பேர் பணிபுரியும் நிறுவனம்.
- தினசரி 3000 புறநோயாளிகள் மற்றும் 1000 உள்நோயாளிகள் பயன்பெறும் ஒரே தனியார் மருத்துவக்கல்லூரி மருத்துவமனை.
- மருத்துவக்கல்லூரி மருத்துவமனையில் பயன்பெறும் நோயாளிகளுக்கு மாதம் 6 கோடி மதிப்புள்ள மருத்துவ சேவைகள் (MRI, CT, Doppler, Implants பரிசோதனை தவிர்த்து) இலவசமாக வழங்கப்படுகிறது.
- உயர்சிறப்பு சிகிச்சைகளில் மற்ற தனியார் பல்நோக்கு மருத்துவமனைகளை விட 25% கட்டணம் குறைவு.
- அனைத்து நோய்களுக்கும் சிகிச்சை அளிக்கக்கூடிய அனைத்து துறைகளுக்குமான சிறப்பு மருத்துவர்கள்.

எங்களுடைய மருத்துவ சேவையின் மூலம் 2100 படுக்கைகளும் முழுமையாக பொதுமக்களின் நலனுக்கு பயன்படவும், எங்களிடம் கல்வி பயிலும் அனைத்து மருத்துவ மாணவர்களும் சமூகத்திற்கு தரமான மருத்துவ சேவை அளிக்கவும், பொதுமக்கள் அனைவரும் வேலம்மாள் மருத்துவமனைக்கு ஆதரவு நல்குமாறு அன்புடன் வேண்டுகிறோம்.

எம்.வீ.முத்திராமலிங்கம்,

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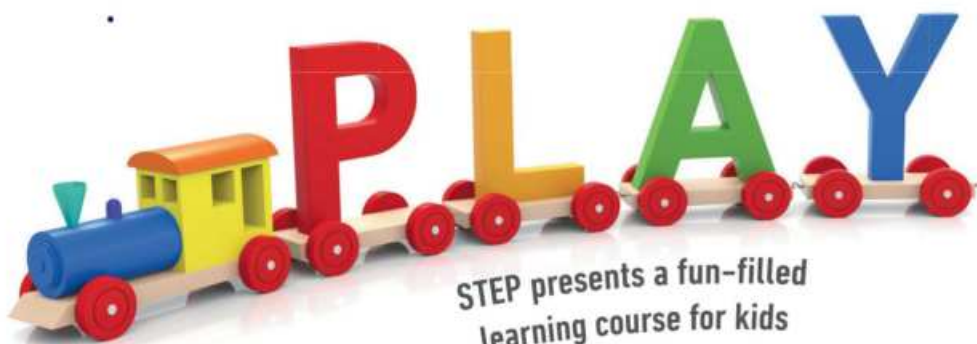








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★

★

★

★

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Do I ensure my security guard has basic facilities?

★

★

★

★

★

Do I think about how my garbage will affect those that collect it?

★

★

★

★

★

Do I give my house help a fair increment?

★

★

★

★

★

Do they have health support or insurance because of me?

★

★

★

★

★

Do I give a poor rating because my ride arrived in 12 minutes, instead of 10?

★

★

★

★

★

Do I lose my cool because they call to confirm my address?

★

★

★

★

★

Do I pay my driver for working overtime?

★

★

★

★

★

Do I treat my service provider with dignity?

★

★

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★

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International Labour Day | May 1, 2026



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STRONG VERBAL ATTACK
Pakistan is 'epicentre of terrorism': Rajnath
NEWS » PAGE 10

RESULTS OUT
Girls excel in CISCE exams
NEWS » PAGE 12





MINOR RAPE CASES
Remove time limit on abortions, says SC
NEWS » PAGE 12

PARLEY
Should the PIL jurisdiction be reconsidered?
Concerns have been raised about misuse
OPINION » PAGE 9



CRUCIAL WIN
Titans get the better of Royal Challengers
SPORT » PAGE 15

Iran vows to safeguard its nuclear capabilities

Tehran will secure Persian Gulf, implement new rules to manage Strait of Hormuz, says Mojtaba Khamenei; U.S. President had earlier said that he wanted a deal from Iran on the nuclear issue

Stanly Johny

Iran's Supreme Leader Mojtaba Khamenei said on Thursday that the country would "safeguard" its "nuclear and missile" capabilities and lay down new rules for managing the Strait of Hormuz, hours after U.S. President Donald Trump said a blockade of Iranian ports would remain until a nuclear deal is reached.

"A new chapter for the Persian Gulf and the Strait of Hormuz is taking shape," he said in a statement, marking Persian Gulf Day. "The Islamic Republic will secure the Persian Gulf region and dismantle the enemies' exploitative schemes in this waterway. The legal frameworks and implementation of new management for the strait will



The Islamic Republic will secure the Persian Gulf region... The legal frameworks and implementation of new management for the strait will bring peace, progress to the benefit of all the region's nations
MOJTABA KHAMENEI, Iran's Supreme Leader



The [U.S.] blockade is somewhat more effective than the bombing... They want to settle. I don't want to [lift the blockade], because I don't want them to have a nuclear weapon
DONALD TRUMP, U.S. President

bring peace and progress to the benefit of all the region's nations," he said.

The war on Iran, launched by the U.S. and Israel, has turned into a maritime battle of wills after Mr. Trump announced a ceasefire on April 8. While the ceasefire is still

holding, Iran's chokehold of the strait, the mouth of the oil-rich Persian Gulf, remains intact. The U.S. has imposed a blockade on Iran-linked vessels in the Gulf of Oman to exert economic pressure on Tehran.

Last week, U.S. media reported that Iran made a

proposal to the U.S. via Pakistan promising to ease its control of the strait in return for the U.S. lifting its blockade. Iran said it would discuss outstanding issues, including the nuclear programme, in the second round.

Mr. Trump, in an interview, said on Wednesday that he wanted a deal from Iran addressing America's core concerns, including the nuclear issue.

"The blockade is somewhat more effective than the bombing... They want to settle. They don't want me to keep the blockade. I don't want to [lift the blockade], because I don't want them to have a nuclear weapon," he said.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10
SHIP HEADS TO STRAIT
» PAGE 11

NEARBY



AIADMK chief rejects exit polls

CHENNAI
Rejecting the exit polls, most of which predicted a win for the DMK-led alliance, AIADMK chief Edappadi K. Palaniswami said that his party would win in 210 constituencies. » PAGE 6

Convicts get time to file appeals

MADURAI
The Madras High Court granted time to the nine policemen, who were sentenced to death for the Sattankulam custodial deaths, time to file appeals against the verdict. » PAGE 6

FRIDAY REVIEW » 6 PAGES

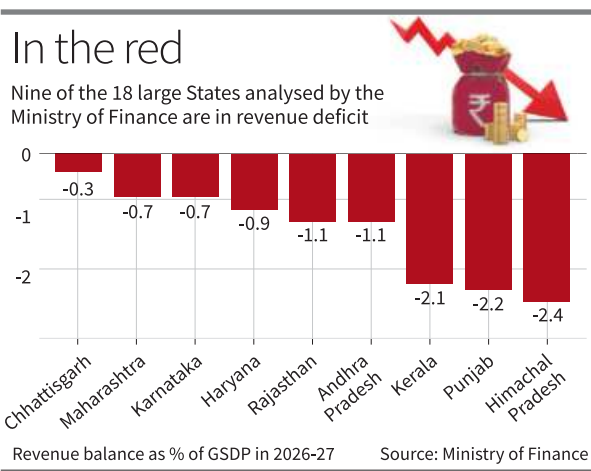
Revenue-deficit States may face fiscal stress, says Centre

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

The Union Finance Ministry has warned that States with revenue deficits and high debt burdens will find it harder to deal with fiscal shocks, including from the West Asia crisis, forcing them to either reprioritise expenditure away from productive areas, or approach the Centre for more funds at a time when it is trying to consolidate its own finances.

In its Monthly Economic Review for April, the Department of Economic Affairs in the Ministry said nine of the 18 large States analysed were in revenue deficit as per their own projections for 2026-27. Seven are projected to be revenue surplus, while one is in revenue balance.

A revenue deficit is



when expenditure on recurring items such as salaries, pensions, subsidies, and interest payments exceeds the revenue earned from sources such as taxes and fees.

The States with projected revenue deficits as a percentage of their gross state domestic products

(GSDP) are Himachal Pradesh (-2.4%), Punjab (-2.2%), Kerala (-2.1%), Andhra Pradesh (-1.1%), Rajasthan (-1.1%), Haryana (-0.9%), Karnataka (-0.7%), Maharashtra (-0.7%), and Chhattisgarh (-0.3%).

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10

Youth convicted in the 2024 rape and murder of minor girl in Puducherry

Rajesh B. Nair
PUDUCHERRY

M.D. Sumathi, Special Judge of the Fast Track Court in Puducherry, on Thursday found Kaka alias Karnas, the lone surviving accused, guilty of all charges in the sexual assault and murder of a nine-year-old girl in the Union Territory in 2024.

The judge found him guilty of the charges, including gang-rape, murder, and kidnapping, under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act and other



Proven guilty: Karnas being produced in a court on Thursday. The sentence will be awarded on May 5. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

laws. Later, she posted the case to May 5 for sentencing.

The girl was found mis-

sing on March 2 that year. Three days later, her body was recovered from a neighbourhood drain. The

police received information that the girl was last seen with Karnas, who was then 20 years old and living next to her house.

The interrogation of Karnas led to the arrest of his associate, Vivekanandhan, 56, who was also known to the child.

Vivekanandhan died by suicide in the toilet of the Central Prison at Kalapet where he was lodged. The charges against Vivekanandhan thereafter stood abated.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 6



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From Page One

Youth convicted of rape and murder of minor



Protests erupted after the child went missing on March 2, 2024. Her body was found three days later. FILE PHOTO

After the judge gave her verdict on Thursday, Special Public Prosecutor S. Patcheappan told reporters that the prosecution would urge her to consider the case as the rarest of rare for awarding the death penalty to Karnas. “The sentence will be awarded on May 5. It is a fit case for the death penalty as all charges levelled against the accused are heinous. The judge has found the accused guilty of crimes under all Sections invoked against him,” he said.

The Sections invoked against Karnas included 376 AB (punishment for rape of a woman aged below 12); 302 (punishment for murder); 367 (punishment for kidnapping a person with the intent to hurt); 368 (punishment for wrongfully concealing or keeping in confinement, kidnapped or abducted person); 342 (punishment for wrongful confinement); 201 (punishment for causing disappearance of evidence); and 34 (punishment for crime done by two or more persons in furtherance of common intention) of the Indian Penal Code (IPC).

The other charges made against the accused pertained to Section 5 (j) (iv) (g) (m)/6 of the POCSO Act and Section 3 (2) (v), 3 (1) (w) (i) of the Scheduled Castes and the Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act.

(Assistance for overcoming suicidal thoughts is available on Tele-MANAS 14416 and Sneha's suicide prevention helpline 044- 24640050.)

HC grants custodial death case convicts time to file appeals

The nine policemen were sentenced to death by a trial court in Madurai for the death of trader P. Jayaraj and his son J. Benicks in Sattankulam



Facing justice: On April 6, Madurai First Additional District and Sessions Judge G. Muthukumaran awarded the death penalty to the policemen. FILE PHOTO

The Hindu Bureau
MADURAI

The Madurai Bench of the Madras High Court on Thursday granted time to the nine policemen, who were sentenced to death by a trial court in Madurai for the custodial death of trader P. Jayaraj, 58, and his son J. Benicks, 31, at Sattankulam in Thoothukudi district in June 2020, to file their appeals against the trial court judgment.

A Division Bench of Justices N. Anand Venkatesh and K.K. Ramakrishnan, hearing the referred trial, granted time to the nine convicts: the then Sattan-

kulam Inspector, S. Sridhar; Sub-Inspectors P. Raghu Ganesh and K. Balakrishnan; Head Constables S. Murugan and A. Saamidurai; and Constables M. Muthuraj, S. Cheladurai, X. Thomas Francis, and S. Veilumuthu.

Hearing on June 4

The court posted the matter to June 4 for hearing. Special Sub-Inspector Pauldurai, who was also named as an accused in the case, died of COVID-19.

On April 6, Madurai First Additional District and Sessions Judge G. Muthukumaran awarded the death penalty to the policemen.

On March 23, the judge held the nine policemen guilty of the crime.

The father and son were detained at the Sattankulam police station on the charge of violating the COVID-19 lockdown norms by keeping their mobile phone sales and service showroom open.

The CBI said its investigation revealed that the traders had not violated the norms, and the policemen had subjected them to torture, knowing it would cause their death. The two were wrongfully confined at the police station and beaten up to teach them how to behave with the police, it said.

QR code-based photo ID cards to prevent unauthorised access to counting centres

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Election Commission of India (EC) has introduced a QR code-based photo identity card module on ECINET to prevent unauthorised persons from entering the counting centres.

The system will come into force for the vote-counting to be held on May 4 for the Assembly elections in Tamil Nadu and three other States and the Union Territory of Puducherry, and the byelections to seven Assembly constituencies in five States. It will be extended to all elections in future, the EC said in a press release.

The initiative is in continuation of the 30 measures taken by the EC in the past year, including the introduction of standardised QR code-based photo identity cards for booth-level officers. A three-tier security mechanism has been prescribed for verification of identity at the counting centres. In the first and second tiers, photo identity cards issued by the Returning Officer shall be checked manually, the release said.

In the third and innermost security ring near the counting hall, entry will be permitted only af-

The system will come into force for the counting to be held on May 4 for the Assembly polls, and will be extended to all elections in future

ter successful verification through scanning of QR code. The QR code-based photo identity cards will be applicable to the categories of persons authorised by the EC to enter the counting centres and halls. Among them are the Returning Officers, Assistant Returning Officers, counting staff, technical personnel, the candidates, the election agents, and the counting agents.

The District Election Officers and the Returning Officers have been directed to ensure the effective implementation of this system, including the deployment of trained personnel at designated checkpoints, the release said.

All Chief Electoral Officers, District Election Officers, Returning Officers, and Assistant Returning Officers have been directed to ensure compliance with these instructions to uphold the highest standards of transparency, security, and efficiency in the counting process, it added.

EPS rejects exit polls, says AIADMK will win 210 seats

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Rejecting the exit polls, most of which predicted a victory for the DMK-led alliance in the recently held Assembly election, AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami on Thursday expressed hope that his party would win in 210 constituencies.

“Our party’s uniqueness lies in the fact that it has always demolished the exit polls, and has risen in every election. It would do so in this election, too. The AIADMK will win in 210 constituencies. The AIADMK will form the government with a majority,” Mr. Palaniswami said in a statement.

Suspects ‘conspiracy’ Suspecting a “conspiracy” behind such exit polls, Mr. Palaniswami said Chief Minister and DMK president M.K. Stalin was aware that his party would lose, adding that DMK members would attempt to create an impression that it was set to win.

Urging members of his party not to pay heed to the exit polls, Mr. Palaniswami said these were merely attempts to divert attention.

Recalling the exit polls in 2011, which predicted that the DMK would remain in power, Mr. Palaniswami pointed out that the AIADMK had emerged victorious.

99.91% of students pass Class 10 ICSE, Class 12 ISC exams in T.N.

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu recorded a pass percentage of 99.91 for the Indian School Certificate (ISC) Class 12 exams and the Indian Certificate of Secondary Education (ICSE) Class 10 exams.

The results for the exams, held by the Council for the Indian School Certificate Examinations (CISCE), were announced on Thursday.

A total of 3,305 students from 88 schools in the State appeared for the Class 12 exams. While girls achieved a pass rate of 99.93%, boys recorded 99.89% pass.

A total of 6,431 students from 131 schools across the State had registered for the ICSE exams. All the girls

who appeared for the exams passed, while the pass rate for boys was 99.83%. Nationally, the pass rate was 99.18% for the ICSE exams, and 99.13% for the ISC exams.

A total of 4,265 Other Backward Classes candidates took the Class 10 examinations, and achieved a pass rate of 99.95%. A total of 1,662 General Category candidates achieved a pass rate of 99.76%.

A total of 2,148 Other Backward Classes candidates wrote the Class 12 exams with 100% pass rate, while 985 General Category candidates wrote them with 99.07% pass rate.

Most schools in Chennai registered a 100% pass rate. Speaking to *The Hindu*, Sujatha S.M., principal of The Grove School, said

the top score in the school was 99%.

“The overall results were very good this year. Every year, the council has been trying to standardise the paper, and the children have performed really well. This year, we had four children with disabilities taking up the ICSE exam, and they performed really well,” she said.

The candidates can access their results through the official CISCE websites and the DigiLocker platform, while the schools may download detailed tabulation registers from the CISCE CAREERS portal.

The recheck window will be open from May 1 to 4, followed by re-evaluation and improvement exams in June and July.

Former Director of MRF Ramarathnam Srinivasan no more

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Ramarathnam Srinivasan, former Director of Corporate Planning and Diversification at MRF, passed away in Mysuru after a brief illness on Thursday. He was 89.

After doing his schooling at P.S. High School, Chennai; his B.Sc. at Vivekananda College, Chennai; and his B.Tech at Annamalai University, he joined MRF Limited in the early 1960s.

He served the company in various capacities, and retired in 2003.

He was closely associated with the MRF Pace Foundation in its formative



Ramarathnam Srinivasan

years, working with Dennis Lillie and T.A. Sekhar.

He was a grandson of Kasturi Gopalan, former Publisher of *The Hindu*.

He is survived by his wife, Ramya Ramarathnam, and their three children, Arvind, Harini, and Priya.

Vijay holds meeting with TVK candidates ahead of poll results

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

TVK president C. Joseph Vijay on Thursday held a meeting with key office-bearers and candidates who contested the recently held Assembly election at the party headquarters in Panaiyur on the outskirts of Chennai.

The meeting was attended by party general secretary N. Anand, chief coordinator of the high-level committee K.A. Sengottaiyan, and party general secretary (election campaign management) Aadhav Arjuna, among others.

According to TVK sources, the meeting lasted more than an hour. Mr. Vijay interacted with the candidates, and laid down the procedures they needed to



C. Joseph Vijay

The meeting assumes significance against the backdrop of the exit polls released for four States

follow during the counting of votes on May 4.

The sources added that Mr. Vijay had asked the candidates to remain con-

fident, and sought feedback on ground reports and victory prospects.

Sessions on the counting of votes were held in batches.

The meeting assumes significance against the backdrop of the exit polls released a day earlier for four States, including Tamil Nadu. While many pollsters predicted a majority for the DMK-led Secular Progressive Alliance, a few gave a lead for the TVK.

The TVK contested 233 seats, barring Edappadi, where it extended support to an independent candidate following the rejection of the nomination filed by the party's candidate. Mr. Vijay contested from two seats - Perambur and Tiruchi East.

Devotees throng streets of Madurai to catch a glimpse of Lord Kallazhagar

The Hindu Bureau
MADURAI

Thousands of devotees thronged the streets of Madurai to welcome Lord Kallazhagar, who entered the city on Thursday morning.

Devotees gathered for ‘Ethir Sevai’ to catch a glimpse of the deity who, mounted on a golden palanquin, left his abode at Alagarkoil on Wednesday evening, as part of the annual Chithirai festival. Lord Kallazhagar began his journey to Madurai around 6.15 p.m. on Wednesday from Alagarkoil. After a halt at Appan Tirupathi, he reached Moondrumavadi around 6 a.m. on Thursday.

The devotees welcomed him at the ‘mandagapadis’ at various points, including



Sea of faith: Devotees gathering for ‘Ethir Sevai’ at Outpost in Madurai on Thursday. Lord Kallazhagar began his journey to Madurai around 6.15 p.m. on Wednesday from Alagarkoil. R. ASHOK

K. Pudur, Reserve Line, Bharathi Ula Road, and Outpost.

‘Ethir Sevai’ is a tradition of offering prayers to the Lord, who visits his devotees instead of the devotees visiting the temple.

Lord Kallazhagar made halts at more than 500 ‘mandagapadis’ en route to the Prasanna Venkatachalapathy Temple at Talakulam, where he arrived at 8 p.m. From there, the deity would begin his jour-

ney to the Vaigai in the early hours of Friday.

Devotees gathered at the ‘mandagapadis’ with flowers and garlands as offerings to the deity, and followed the Lord as he went on the journey.

Chithirai festival not merely temple event, but civilisational continuum, says court

The Hindu Bureau
MADURAI

Taking a serious view of miscreants throwing footwear on devotees during Lord Kallazhagar’s ceremonial journey culminating in the deity’s entry into the Vaigai as part of the Chithirai festival, Justice L. Victoria Gowri of the Madurai Bench of the Madras High Court has issued a set of directions for the authorities to prevent such incidents.

She was hearing a petition filed by P. Sundaravadivel of Madurai, who had sought a direction to the authorities to take preventive measures. Justice Gowri said throwing footwear at devotees in the midst of a divine procession was not only an act of disorder but was also an affront to

faith, an assault upon customary religious practice, and a desecration of the secular fraternity that formed part of the constitutional ethos. “The Chithirai festival is not merely a temple event. It is a civilisational continuum, a living embodiment of Tamil heritage, rooted in the Sangam culture, and nourished through centuries. The festival, in its present form, represents the confluence of Meenakshi Amman Temple traditions and Kallazhagar Temple traditions, symbolically uniting Shaivite and Vaishnavite streams in a singular expression of devotional harmony,” she said.

Cultural capital

The judge said Madurai, celebrated in the Sangam literature as Koodal, had

stood for millennia as the cultural capital of Tamil civilisation. This annual festival is a reminder that faith in India is not a private abstraction but a public cultural experience woven into the life of the people.

“Participation of lakhs of devotees cutting across caste, creed, and economic barriers transforms the festival into a living expression of secular fraternity, secularism in its truest Indian sense, namely equal reverence and peaceful coexistence of diverse traditions,” the court said.

“Any act intended to insult or disrupt such a sacred observance, therefore, has implications transcending ordinary breach of peace. To preserve such festivals is not merely to preserve ritual. It is to preserve the beauty and comi-

ty of the secular spirit of this democratic Republic,” it added.

The State assured the court of peaceful conduct of the procession. The court directed the Madurai Commissioner of Police to deploy 15-20 striking force vehicles along the 7.6-km route of the procession. At least 10 striking force vehicles should be stationed in the riverbed area.

“Any person found indulging in throwing footwear or any disruptive act should be immediately apprehended on the spot and proceeded against in accordance with law, and appropriate remand proceedings shall be initiated forthwith. Preventive and intelligence-based policing shall be intensified throughout the festival period,” the judge directed.

The Election Commission (EC) has approved 'Telangana Rakshana Sena' as the name for K. Kavitha's new party, from the five names she suggested. With the EC nod, she should now publish public notices, seeking objections, if any, to the name, a mandatory requirement before the registration of a political party. At her party's recent launch, Ms. Kavitha, daughter of BRS founder B. Chandrasekhara Rao, had announced that it would be named 'Telangana Rashtra Sena'.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi will launch development initiatives worth ₹7,823 crore and launch several projects for Telangana during his visit to Hyderabad on May 10. At a press meet in Hyderabad on Thursday, Union Minister G. Kishan Reddy said Mr. Modi will lay the foundation stone for national highway projects worth around ₹3,175 crore in the Mahabubnagar region. He will also virtually inaugurate a major petroleum products terminal at Mallapur.

The Karnataka government is ready to conduct a re-examination for students who were asked to remove their *janivara* (sacred thread) and hijab during the recently held Common Entrance Test (CET). Addressing the media in Bengaluru on Thursday, Higher Education Minister M.C. Sudhakar said, "If the affected students wish to take a re-examination, we will provide an option. Awarding grace marks is ruled out as it will create legal issues."

"Some may say that I should become the Chief Minister. You may say so, and even the high command may think the same way. In our party, most of the decisions are taken by Sonia Gandhi. But this question does not arise now, as there is already a Chief Minister in Karnataka. When required, Ms. Gandhi, Rahul Gandhi, and all of us will sit together and discuss. It takes time," he said.

CO: Carbon monoxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.

PM_{2.5} & PM₁₀: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease

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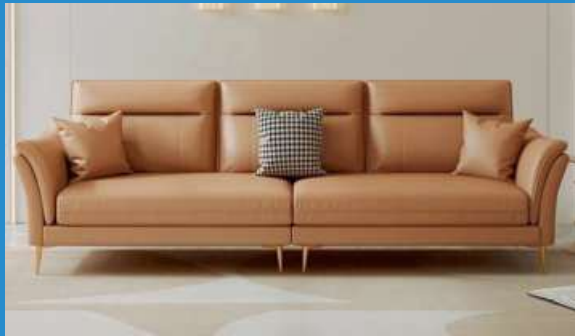
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Gulf within

Differences with Saudi Arabia and Iran's attacks led to the UAE's exit from OPEC

The UAE has withdrawn from the Organization of the Petroleum Exporting Countries (OPEC), a cartel that it joined in 1967, and OPEC+. It was OPEC's fourth-largest producer (3.12 million barrels per day) and its third-largest exporter (2.88 mbd) in 2025, behind Saudi Arabia and Iraq. The Emiratis clearly sought to free themselves of production constraints set largely by the cartel's dominant producer, Saudi Arabia. With significant spare capacity, the Emiratis believe that they are better off with the autonomy to ramp up exports, a capability now constrained by the de facto closure of the Strait of Hormuz, the largest disruption to oil supply in history, following U.S.-Israel attacks on Iran. Brent crude prices barely budged on the announcement, revealing how heavily the Strait crisis weighs on the market. But once the UAE weathers this crisis, whether through the Strait's reopening, or by routing more crude through a pipeline bypassing Hormuz, analysts estimate that it could lift production by roughly a million barrels a day. While Saudi Arabia, OPEC's bellwether, has remained chary of over-supply and sought to keep prices high, the UAE has long pushed for higher production for revenues that it intends to funnel into AI infrastructure and other diversification projects.

Unsaid in the UAE's move is also its frustration with what it sees as a lack of cartel-wide coordination in responding to Iran's missile and drone attacks on Gulf oil and military facilities; Iran is also an OPEC member. The Emiratis have also differed sharply with the Saudis on external interventions: in Yemen and Sudan. The UAE also seeks closer ties with Israel than most Gulf states, which remain uncomfortable with any thaw given Israel's genocidal actions in Gaza and its attacks on Iran and Lebanon. The U.S., a non-OPEC member, and the world's largest oil producer at 13.6 mbd, has long viewed the cartel's price-setting unfavourably, and President Donald Trump has repeatedly pressed it to pump more. The UAE perhaps calculates that aligning with Washington will yield benefits for its production and pipeline ambitions, though Mr. Trump's transactional and mercurial foreign policy offers little guarantee. The UAE's exit also reflects a structural issue: OPEC's share of global crude dropped to 36.7% in 2025, and with Hormuz shut, pricing power has shifted to American producers in the short term. OPEC will continue, but with a reduced ability to set prices. For net oil-importing countries such as India, however, the immediate threat is not the cartel's unravelling but the "double blockade" in the Strait of Hormuz and the fragile Iran-U.S. ceasefire. Unless a new geopolitical détente emerges between Iran and the Gulf states, volatility will persist, threatening energy security regardless of what unfolds within OPEC.

Embers in the air

Seasonal fires need long-term management, not just preparedness

The Nilgiris district in Tamil Nadu and the adjoining forest divisions of Mudumalai, Coimbatore and Erode have been dealing with wildfires that escalated to being a crisis requiring the assistance of the Indian Air Force. Even so, the intense fires are not anomalous, but an acute manifestation of a seasonal event. Parsons Valley and Pykara in the Nilgiris have been worst-hit while significant blazes were also reported from the Singara and Masinagudi ranges. One major blaze broke out in Wenlock Downs and spread rapidly. February to May is fire season in this region, and in April, officials said that high heat and strong winds created a "conductive environment"; the wind, in particular, carried embers over pre-existing firelines and partly explains why this season has been a breakout. Some fires also burnt hotter and for longer in Pykara because of the accumulated biomass and invasive undergrowth, and took longer to be doused. The Nilgiris feature steep terrains and limited road access, slowing the movement of crew and equipment to particular spots. This said, most fires also have a human hand. Tribespeople gather wood in the area to make brooms – an activity closely monitored by officials – and herders have also been known to burn dry grassland, forcing grasses to regrow and become fodder. The latter together with discarded smoking paraphernalia are known accidental causes. This year, one blaze entered the Coimbatore division after Kerala forest staff began a controlled burn allegedly without coordinating this with Tamil Nadu. Some officials also expressed suspicion that miscreants deliberately set fires in the Reserve, allegedly over the Forest Department's failure to address tiger-related deaths meaningfully, but local communities are usually the first-responders to these fires.

While none of these causes is new, their confluence this year with the hot summer is likely to have stoked the intense fires. Indeed, climate variability – rather than climate change alone – is also raising the baseline risk. Keeping other causes fixed, a hotter, drier summer automatically leads to fires that threaten the best-laid plans more. Even this year, authorities had begun planning in March, setting up control rooms and firelines, ensuring animals' access to water outside human-settled areas, clearing weeds, and mounting awareness campaigns. However, many activities that add to the fire risk remain tied to peoples' livelihoods and traditional practices, so they cannot be eliminated without suitable alternatives. Taken together, managing the region's seasonal fires is becoming less about what can be planned for in the short term and more about what can be factored in over the long term.

This year, May Day arrives not as a commemoration, but as a diagnosis. Within a single fortnight last month, two events clarified the state of Indian labour more sharply than any official review.

On April 10, thousands of garment workers in Noida's Phase 2 Hosiery Complex stepped out of nearly 300 factories and onto the streets, demanding a minimum monthly wage of ₹20,000. On April 14, a high-pressure steam tube ruptured at Vedanta's 1,200 MW Singhitara thermal plant in Chhattisgarh, killing 20 workers and injuring 15. One protest was about the price of labour; the other, about the price of being alive while performing it. Both answer the same question: what has India's labour reform actually produced?

The Noida strike began with a specific arithmetic grievance. On April 9, the Haryana government notified a 35% hike in minimum wages, raising unskilled monthly wages from ₹11,274 to ₹15,220, with effect from April 1, 2026. Across the border in Noida, unskilled workers were earning roughly ₹435 a day, compared to ₹585 in Haryana for identical work. Protesters at the Hosiery Complex – employees of different companies – assembled in B Block, blocked traffic, and refused to disperse without written assurances.

By April 13, the administration had deployed over 1,200 personnel, including the Provincial Armed Constabulary and Rapid Action Force; lathi charges and stone-pelting followed, and nearly 400 people were detained. Under pressure, the Uttar Pradesh government announced an interim 21% hike, setting wages at ₹13,690 for unskilled workers in Gautam Buddh Nagar and ₹16,868 for skilled workers. The workers rejected it; their demand remained ₹20,000.

Between pay and survival

The gap between ₹16,868 and ₹20,000 is not a bargaining position. It is the difference between what a family pays for rent, gas, and school fees in the NCR and what the state is willing to concede as a dignified minimum.

Four days later, the furnace at Singhitara did its own counting. A preliminary report from the Chief Boiler Inspector, backed by the Forensic Science Laboratory in Sakti, Chhattisgarh, attributed the explosion to 'excessive fuel buildup inside the furnace', which produced pressure surges that displaced critical piping. The probe flagged "repeated negligence in equipment upkeep" by Vedanta and its contractor NGSL (NTPC GE Power Services Pvt. Ltd.). A first information report has been registered against Vedanta's Chairman Anil Agarwal, the plant manager, and others under Sections 106(1), 289 and 3(5) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita.

The dead were not Vedanta's own employees; they worked for a subcontractor. This, too, is a pattern.



Rejimon Kuttappan

A workers' rights expert

From Noida's streets to furnace rooms in Chhattisgarh, India's new labour regime delivers for employers – and for workers, what it long warned of

Chhattisgarh alone has recorded 296 industrial deaths over three years. Across India, the Directorate General of Factory Advice Service and Labour Institutes recorded 3,331 factory deaths between 2018 and 2020 – three a day – yet only 14 people were imprisoned under the Factories Act during the same period. The global union IndustriALL counted over 400 workplace fatalities in India in 2024, with the chemical sector alone accounting for 220. In July 2025, an explosion at Sigachi Industries in Telangana had killed 44 people, mostly migrant workers, at a plant that the State fire department found lacked basic fire alarms and heat sensors.

A structural shift

These are not disconnected episodes. They are the operating conditions of an economy that, on November 21, 2025, formally adopted the four labour codes. In a single stroke, and without any transition period, the four codes – the Code on Wages, the Industrial Relations Code, the Social Security Code and the Occupational Safety, Health and Working Conditions (OSHWC) Code – replaced 29 central labour laws. The Indian Labour Conference, the country's apex tripartite forum, had not been convened since 2015.

The new regime raises the threshold for prior government permission for layoffs, retrenchment, and closure from 100 workers to 300 under the Industrial Relations Code, 2020, enabling firms below that size – an estimated majority of India's factory units – to retrench workers without administrative scrutiny. A peer-reviewed analysis in the National Library of Medicine archive notes that this merely restores the pre-1982 threshold, reversing an Emergency-era protection enacted after a wave of mass layoffs affected over half a million workers.

The OSHWC Code, 2020, simultaneously raises the statutory definition of a 'factory' from 10 workers in a factory with power to 20, and from 20 workers in a factory without power to 40, lifting an entire tier of smaller workplaces – where India's textile, garment, metal, hosiery, and food-processing clusters are concentrated – out of mandatory safety oversight. Labour economists warn that this technical reclassification has a profound impact on worker coverage, since a majority of India's small manufacturing units employ fewer than 20 workers.

The inspection architecture has been similarly diluted. The OSHWC Code replaces unannounced inspections with an 'Inspector-cum-Facilitator' model, combined with randomised, web-based allocation through the Shram Suidhda portal and employer self-certification – a shift that, as the International Labour Organization's India Labour Inspection Profile notes, may contravene the requirement for independent, unannounced inspections under ILO Convention No. 81.

Procedural hurdles for collective action have also stiffened. Under the IR Code, no worker may

strike without 60 days' prior notice, flash strikes are prohibited outright, and strikes are barred during and for weeks after any conciliation or tribunal proceeding. "Mass casual leave" by more than 50% of a workforce is now deemed a strike. Trade unions argue that, in combination, these provisions make lawful industrial action virtually impossible to organise, completing the regime's pro-employer tilt.

A reform that raises statutory thresholds in almost every operative clause, is not rationalising protection. It is removing it. The enforcement chapters read more like a facilitation framework than a compliance regime.

Ten central trade unions, including the Bharatiya Mazdoor Sangh (BMS), observed a "Black Day" on November 26, 2025, calling the codes a "deceptive fraud on the working class". Their objection was not sentimental. When the legal definition of a factory excludes the smallest and most dangerous workplaces; when inspectors announce their visits through a portal; when retrenchment requires no permission below 300 workers; and when strikes are bound by procedural tightropes, the predictable result is the Noida street and the Singhitara shop floor.

The wage stagnation that drove workers from Motherson Sumi and Richa Global into a baton charge, and the deferred maintenance that caused a boiler tube to rupture, are not separate problems. They are two ends of the same system.

Old laws, new realities

There is an honest public case for labour reform. The Factories Act of 1948 is older than most Indian States; the Workmen's Compensation Act of 1923 predates the Constitution. A regulatory architecture built for the industrial economy of late-colonial India – of jute mills, textile mills, and railway workshops – cannot plausibly govern a workforce that today includes gig workers, platform workers, and digital-media workers. No serious observer, and no Indian trade union, disputes that consolidation was overdue. The question is not whether the law should have changed; it is what it changed into.

Consolidation is not dilution, and simplification is not exemption.

On May Day, the test for any labour framework is modest: does it allow a worker to earn enough to live, and to live through the shift? In April 2026, the answer from Noida and Singhitara is the same. In Noida, police fired tear gas at factory workers protesting for a living wage as fuel-driven inflation outpaced wages. In Singhitara, a boiler tube burst at a Vedanta power plant on April 14, releasing 600°C steam onto workers eating lunch; 20 were killed, all contract workers employed through a business partner rather than as direct employees. Neither a wage that sustains life, nor a workplace that preserves it. A regime that cannot deliver the second while pricing out the first has not been rationalised. It has been rewritten against the very people it was meant to protect.

India's sprint beyond the dairy red line to the Pacific

India concluded a Free Trade Agreement (FTA) with New Zealand in December 2025, at a time marked by fractured supply chains and rising protectionist tendencies among nations. Guided by the vision of "Viksit Bharat", India has recalibrated its foreign trade policy, transitioning from a cautious, tariff-focused negotiator to a strategic, high-velocity partner. This shift characterises a clear departure from the historical "slow burn" model of trade diplomacy. There are six key wins for India in this FTA, as it aligns with the Viksit Bharat blueprint for trade policy based on strategic autonomy and global integration."

India's rapid FTA execution

First, this pact is one of India's fastest-concluded FTAs, with negotiations officially launched in March 2025 and concluded in December 2025. This gives India a first-mover advantage in Oceania while also signalling its swift institutional integration and ambitious posture to other partners. This fresh display of efficiency and the ability to compress negotiation cycle times is a new deliverable from India to its trade partners.

Second, this FTA embeds talent mobility as a core economic pillar with the "Yoga and Māori" reciprocity between the two nations. There are many provisions for human capital outflow, including professional pathways, youth engagement and bi-directional exchange of traditional medicine. The FTA allows for a separate annual quota of 5,000 professional visas for skilled Indian professionals in high-skill jobs



Ritu Srivastava

Associate Professor, Economics, K.J. Somaiya Institute of Management

The Free Trade Agreement with New Zealand reflects India's evolving trade diplomacy strategy

such as IT, engineering, and health care, with a tenure period of up to three years. An annual quota of 1,000 work-and-holiday visas will also be permitted for young Indians, aligning India's workforce with New Zealand's age requirements. Most importantly, it is the first bilateral reciprocity agreement that will allow international recognition of India's Ayurveda, Yoga, Unani, Siddha, and Homoeopathy (AYUSH) system along with the native Māori health practices of New Zealand.

Third, the FTA lays down a commitment of capital inflow of around \$20 billion over a period of 15 years in high-priority sectors such as agri-tech and food processing, renewable energy, education and health-care management, wherein New Zealand's technology and capital will be the much-needed catalyst for growth. This influx will also strengthen the "Make in India" programme.

Strategically shielded

Fourth, India has been so far successful in negotiating for an agreement which protects one of the sensitive sectors of India's economy – "dairy". The mechanics of the pact include the exclusion of fluid milk, cheese, and yogurt from duty concessions. India will grant progressive market access, on a duty-free basis, for infant formula and high-value-added dairy products, over a seven-year period, allowing domestic nutritional firms access to quality raw materials. The pact proposes a "Ring Fenced Value Addition Framework" to boost downstream processing of manufacturing. Under this agreement, New

Zealand firms are permitted to import dairy products from India duty-free for manufacturing purposes, if 100% of the products are exported out of India. The pact uses an advanced tariff rate quota mechanism, providing for a minimum import price and seasonal constraints on select commodities such as apples, honey, and kiwifruit.

The fifth win is that New Zealand has pledged to change its legislation within 18 months. This change will provide Indian Geographical Indication (GI) products with protection such as that offered by the European Union. As a result, brands such as Darjeeling tea and Basmati rice will receive top-quality legal protection in Oceania.

Securing a South Pacific foothold

Last, this FTA with New Zealand is increasingly significant, as it creates a geopolitical hedge for India and opens new markets, with New Zealand serving as a gateway to Oceania and the Pacific Island countries (PICs). By adopting New Zealand's trade regulations and norms, India secures a logistical centre and "regulatory reference point" in the South Pacific. Through this trade agreement, India demonstrates its ability to meet Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) standards and sets a precedent for further negotiations with other partners. The FTA signals India's ability to open and engage in global supply chains while maintaining a balance between market access and domestic protection.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

The UAE's move

The United Arab Emirates' shift away from the Organization of the Petroleum Exporting Countries should be seen less as a rupture and more as a recalibration of energy sovereignty within an increasingly fragmented geopolitical order. While the broader backdrop includes tensions involving the United States, Israel and Iran, the immediate driver lies in the UAE's effort to align its expanding production capacity with strategic autonomy. Energy is no longer insulated from

security alignments; it now reflects shifting partnerships, contested regional influence, and the desire for fiscal flexibility in an uncertain global economy. For India, the implications are nuanced. A loosening of OPEC discipline may create room for more diversified and competitive sourcing, particularly with the UAE enhancing India's bargaining power in energy procurement. However, this potential advantage is offset by heightened volatility in West Asia, where instability around key maritime routes

such as the Strait of Hormuz can quickly translate into supply risk. India's strategic interest, therefore, lies in balance: leveraging a more fluid oil market to secure diversified, cost-effective supplies while simultaneously strengthening energy security through strategic reserves, supply diversification, and carefully calibrated diplomacy across competing regional blocs. **Vijay Singh Adhikari**, Nainital, Uttarakhand

Exit polls

Far from being harmless

indicators, exit polls have increasingly become tools that distort public perception and weaken democratic seriousness. These polls are often based on questionable sampling methods and incomplete data. Yet, they are presented with an air of authority. This creates a misleading narrative of certainty even before the official results are declared. Such premature conclusions risk influencing public sentiment and may even affect voter behaviour in multi-phase elections. Equally alarming is the role

of the media which amplifies these projections through sensational debates and speculative analysis. Instead of encouraging informed discussion on policies and governance, attention is diverted to a numbers game driven by guesswork. It is imperative that stricter regulations be imposed on the dissemination of exit polls, and that media organisations exercise greater responsibility. Democracy deserves thoughtful engagement, not theatrics built on uncertain

predictions. **Nagarajamani M.V.**, Hyderabad

Teen Digest

Congratulations to *The Hindu* on the launch of *The Hindu Teen Digest*, the "refreshed weekend offering for teenagers". This thoughtful initiative for readers who will be tomorrow's leaders is a commendable investment in the nation's future.

T.S. Karthik, Chennai

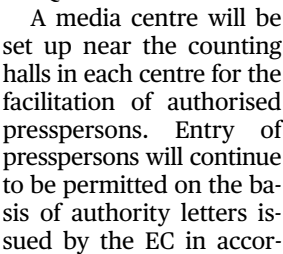
Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

The Bench reserved Mr. Khara's plea for pre-arrest bail for judgment after hearing submissions from both sides for about an hour.

EC set to implement QR code-based access at counting centres

A three-tier security mechanism has been prescribed for verification of identity at counting centres. At the first and second tiers, photo identity cards issued by the Returning Officer (RO) shall be checked manually. At the third and innermost security cordon near the counting hall, entry shall be permitted only after successful verification through QR code-scanning.

The new QR code-based



The DEOs and ROs have been directed to make all necessary arrangements for the effective implementation of this system, including deployment of trained personnel at designated checkpoints to ensure seamless and secure access control.

Alleging EVM tampering, Mamata visits counting centre in Kolkata

seat Firhad Hakim reached the spot but failed to meet the Chief Minister who was already inside the strong room along with her election agent. "I reached here upon learning that the Chief Minister has arrived.

But I couldn't meet her since she was already inside the premises, exercising her right as a candidate to visit strong rooms. I wasn't allowed there. I will not be able to confirm what exactly is transpiring

Make right to vote a fundamental right: Cong.

He also criticised the

Recalling debates in the Constituent Assembly, he

Slamming the process of special intensive revision (SIR), Mr. Ramesh alleged irregularities in electoral rolls, claiming that large numbers of voters' names had been deleted in some States. "The grandson of

Nandalal Bose, whose illustrations adorn the original Constitution of India, could not vote," the Congress leader said.

'No faith in exit polls'
On exit polls, Mr. Ramesh said he had "no faith" in them, calling them a "racket". "Nobody knows who is conducting these surveys, or what their sample base is," he said, citing the 2021 West Bengal Assembly election as an example where projections went wrong.

'Systemic failures' made tribal man take his sister's skeletal remains to bank, finds probe

A day after the unsettling visuals posted online sparked outrage across the country, the Keonjhar ad-



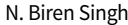
“The CCTV footage does not have audio. However, the man stayed inside the bank for a considerable period of time (11.26 a.m. to

“The bank authorities at Odisha Grameen Bank knew Jitu Munda and the deceased Kalara Munda. Both had withdrawn mo-

He said recommendations would be sent to the State government to strengthen the system in banks to assist people belonging to weaker sections and to those who may have difficulties with banking operations.

SC asks petitioner to turn in first-generation copy of leaked Manipur audio to forensic lab

Justice Kumar said the sanctity of the evidence “degenerated” every time



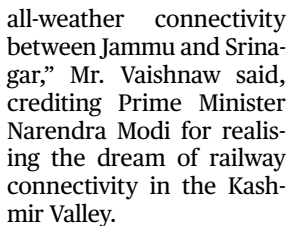
a copy was made,

Advocate Prashant Bhushan, for the NGO, agreed to look up the first generation copy (or the first copy taken from the original recording) of the audiotapes. He said the original device cannot be handed over as that would reveal the identity of the whistle-blower.

Additional Solicitor
General Aishwarya Bhati,

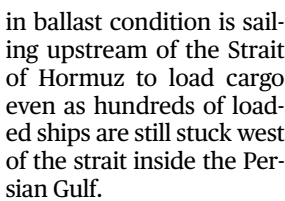
Railway Minister flags off first Jammu-Srinagar direct train

"The introduction of the expanded Vande Bharat service further strengthens this historic corridor, improving travel comfort, meeting rising passenger demand, and reinforcing



The focus, in the future, would be on strengthening maintenance systems, and deploying advanced technologies for bridges and tunnels to ensure safety and reliability in the Himalayan terrain, he said.

Empty LNG ship from Dahej heads into Strait of Hormuz for loading in the UAE's Das Island



The passage of *Umm Al Ashtan* indicates that LNG production is starting at Das Island, which has a capacity of 6 million tonnes per year, almost 1% of global LNG manufacturing ca-

Umm Al Ashtan is managed by Adnoc Logistics and Services, belonging to the well-known Adnoc Group of Abu Dhabi. It has a cargo carrying capacity of 73,100 tonnes and has delivered cargoes to India.

In another India-related LNG shipping, *Mubarak*, an LNG tanker, after loading in Das Island, has transited and is currently *en route* to China but currently cruising on the west coast of India. *Mubarak* had switched off its auto-

matic identification system (AIS) as it transited the strait and sailed into the Arabian Sea. The AIS was switched on as it neared the Indian coast.

Mubaraz, carrying some 59,000 tonnes of LNG and owned by Adnoc's shipping company, was originally scheduled to deliver to India. It was among the 22 energy-carrying ships that the government had earmarked for evacuation to India.

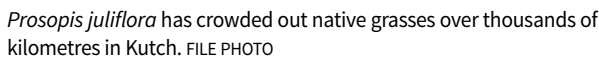
In another positive development, *Idemitsu Maru*, carrying 2 million barrels of crude oil, also transited the strait recently and is headed to Nagoya, Japan.



HC asks Gandhinagar IIT to 'show sympathy' to student

Two days after taking exception to the attire of a postgraduate student at the Indian Institute of Technology, Gandhinagar, observing that people “must maintain dignity and decorum” of the court, the Gujarat High Court on Wednesday advised the institute to “show sympathy” towards the student in her 20s. Justice Nirzar Desai observed that people in their early 20s may not fully understand the consequences of their actions, and that a student may sometimes cross the line for various reasons. The court pointed out that the student had already complied with certain measures, including performing community service and vacating the hostel.

Jacob Koshy
NEW DELHI



The Mexican-origin shrub called *Prosopis juliflora*, known as *Gando Baval* in the region, *Vilayati Keekar* in North India and *Seemai Karuvellam* in Tamil, has crowded out native grasses over thousands of kilometres in Kutch. The plant was first introduced by the British in the 1920s to 'green' Delhi and by the Gujarat Forest Department in 1961 to halt the encroaching salt desert in the Rann. This weed is to become the feedstock for In-

Methanol is used as a fuel in shipping often as a replacement to what is called 'bunker oil'. Conventional methanol is produced from fossil fuels such as gas or coal gasification. Green methanol uses biomass from agricultural residue as source material as in the case with the *juli-*

Ankur Jain, who heads Ankur Scientific, said his company's role lies in the first stage of a two-step process. "The starting point for most fuels and chemicals is going to be syngas because syngas typically has hydrogen, CO and CO₂," he told *The Hinc*.

"It [*juliflora*] is one of the best feedstocks because it is hardwood, dense, has a good energy profile, and low in acids," Mr Jain said, adding Gujarat already wants the species cleared. The plant will be certified to run on other agricultural residues such as bagasse and cotton stalk, which Mr. Jain estimates could, at their maximum potential, displace up to a third of India's oil imports.

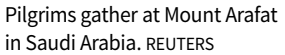
"You should amend the law to remove any time limit on medical termination of unwanted pregnancy caused by the rape of a minor. You should also bring an amendment not only in the MTP Act, but also in the penal law, making it mandatory to complete the trial in such cases in a week. The entire property of the accused should be given to the victim," Chief Justice Kant observed.

Severe trauma

Chief Justice Kant said the 15-year-old had already undergone the trauma of rape. She cannot be compelled to carry and give birth to a child. Her victi-

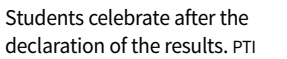
The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

“Amid a sharp global rise in Aviation Turbine Fuel prices, driven by ongoing geopolitical tensions, airlines sought a steep hike of \$300-\$400 per pilgrim. We also can’t blame airlines for the rise in ATF price. Through negotiations, we ensured the increase was restricted to just \$100, saving each pilgrim a significant amount,” he posted on X.



Congress Rajya Sabha MP Imran Pratapgarhi termed the move as unjust. Haj flights began on April 24. According to the Haj Committee, 1.75 lakh pilgrims from across the country are undertaking the pilgrimage this year.

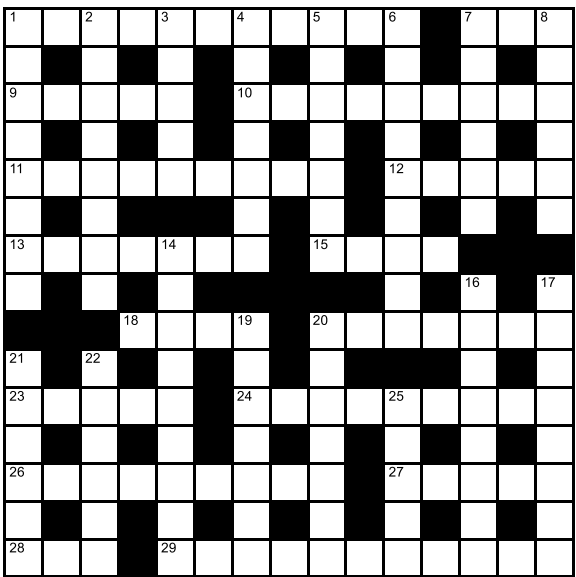
Maitri Porecha
NEW DELHI



“Similarly, the ICSE (Class X) examination recorded an overall pass percentage of 99.18%, with girls achieving a pass rate

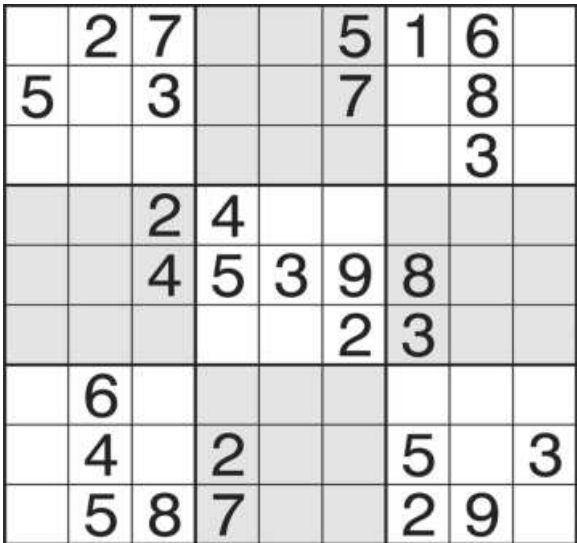
The northern region recorded the highest participation in both the examinations. In the ISC exam, the southern region emerged as the top performer with a pass percentage of 99.87%, followed by the western region at 99.55%. In the ICSE exam, the western region led with 99.85%, closely followed by the Southern region at 99.81%.

Solve this puzzle online and
access more puzzles at
<https://thehindu.com/crosswords>



- 1 Man in the White House blasted and told to sit on his haunches (6,5)
- 7 Openers bowled out - googly for Marsh (3)
- 9 Periodical with nice centrespread, enchanting (5)
- 10 Look, try how to make it fit for flying (9)
- 11 Gin bottles - I'm good working on beds (9)

- 12 Make amends during lunch time (5)
- 13 Come-back star, again falls (7)
- 15 Three cycling, find civic unrest (4)
- 18 I offer in the same place (4)
- 20 There is money in sugar and pepper (7)
- 23 Neat guide (5)
- 24 Emboss over lace inlay found on dinner tables (5,4)
- 26 Bans mob, agrees to disperse (9)
- 27 Story about an Indian antelope... (5)
- 28 .. the climax in the story (3)
- 29 Little overreach perhaps helps you see things clearly (6,5)
- Down**
- 1 Mother's getting old - it's playing havoc (8)
- 2 West African country in a soup (8)
- 3 Small becomes large - it's still money (5)
- 4 One stops running trains for royalty (7)
- 5 Honest state gets conservative support (7)
- 6 For a supporter it's an unknown expletive (9)
- 7 It's crazy, taking half an hour is a let-down (6)
- 8 The Greek has cross eyes like the 'old faithful' in Yellowstone (6)
- 14 Cautionary signal before Green and Red is called floating gold (9)
- 16 Said to be wanting - making some dough? (8)
- 17 Winger's way to block merchant's rise (8)
- 19 Envoy's detailed charter (7)
- 20 Girl in central information commission is model (7)
- 21 Characteristic of a religious order to keep quiet (6)
- 22 One from North Africa is right, repeatedly (6)
- 25 Stand inside a select group (5)



Solution to previous puzzle

S	A	M	N	E	A
S	U	C	R	E	
P	I	K	L	D	
L	A	D	R	O	N
A	H	N	F	N	
S	E	I	G	H	T
H	A	T	E	A	
	D	U	G	O	
P	A	R	I	A	
P	A	R	A	G	O
P	A	R	E	A	
P	A	G	E	R	I
P	A	I	V	E	
P	L	A	N	G	E
	E	R	S	T	

2	5	2	3	9	8	7	1	5	4	6
2	5	7	6	9	3	4	8	2	1	
4	4	1	8	2	5	6	3	9	7	
9	5	7	4	2	3	6	1	8		
8	2	3	6	1	7	4	5	9		
1	6	4	5	9	8	7	3	2		
6	8	1	3	4	2	9	7	5		
7	7	4	5	1	6	9	2	8	3	
3	9	2	7	8	5	1	6	4		

▼

Great souls teach that the Vedas always proclaim the ultimate truth, and they repeatedly affirm the power of the divine name. The Vedas, Puranas, and Upanishads consistently emphasise this, guiding us to value and uphold the chanting of the name and to follow the path set by revered elders. These sacred texts nurture devotees by urging them to love chanting the divine name. Swami Periyavachan Pillai explains that since God's physical presence might go unrecognised, He mercifully grants access to His grace and presence through His name, making chanting a direct connection to the Lord. Scriptures present Lord Vishnu as ultimate protector while giving the divine name equal importance. Especially in Kali Yuga, chanting the divine name emerges as the simplest path to liberation.

INBRIEF



Federal Bank to buy Standard Chartered card unit in part

Federal Bank said it will acquire a part of Standard Chartered Bank’s credit card portfolio in India to expand its customer base in big cities. Standard Chartered is selling a portfolio comprising single-product relationships and transactions which will help it sharpen its focus on the affluent segment, as per an official statement. The portfolio to be acquired comprises up to 4.5 lakh credit cards against Federal Bank’s existing base of 8 lakh non co-branded cards and 13 lakh co-branded cards. Federal Bank’s non-co-branded credit cards receivables would increase by an anticipated 90%, it said. The deal does not require regulatory approvals and is expected to close within the calendar year 2026. The statement refrained from disclosing the final deal amount. PTI

‘Apartment prices rise 8-20% in Jan.-Mar. across top 7 cities’

Apartment prices rose 8-20% in January-March across seven major cities due to rise in input costs and rates could appreciate further although at a slower pace, according to JLL. Real estate consultant JLL India released its data, stating the sales of apartments rose 8% in January-March to 70,631 units across seven cities from 65,222 units in the year-ago period. New supply of apartments increased 13% to 90,023 units. The seven cities are Delhi-NCR, Mumbai, Bengaluru, Pune, Chennai, Hyderabad and Kolkata. Mumbai includes Mumbai city, Mumbai suburbs, Thane city and Navi Mumbai while Delhi-NCR includes Delhi, Gurugram, Noida, Greater Noida, Ghaziabad, Faridabad and Sohna. The data includes only apartments. Row houses, villas, and plotted developments are excluded. PTI

‘Auto PLI puts startups at cost disadvantage’

Jagriti Chandra
NEW DELHI

EV startups have once again called for a tweaks to the auto production linked incentive (PLI) scheme, urging more flexible eligibility criteria that reward innovation rather than reinforcing an imbalance that leaves them at a cost disadvantage compared with legacy OEMs.

“An EV policy architecture that defines champions primarily through legacy scale, not even scale within the EV industry, can create an unintended imbalance. It places emerging EV manufacturers at a 13 to 16% cost disadvantage at a stage where they are continuing to invest heavily in capability building,” wrote Tarun Mehta, co-founder & CEO at Ather Energy.

His post on X comes in response to a report in *The Hindu* that the government does not plan to introduce a separate auto PLI scheme for startups, citing their limited capital, market access, R&D capabilities.

He underlined that a significant share of innovation in indigenous platforms, battery technologies, software, and local value creation is being driven by EV-focused firms well-positioned to set global standards in design and technology.

Tweaks to PLI scheme, through more flexible eligibility criteria, aligned with localisation and the intensity of R&D efforts, would help build “long term capability, not just near-term scale,” he said.

The Centre earmarked about ₹42,500 crore for the PLI. To qualify, vehicle makers must meet a minimum global revenue threshold of ₹10,000 crore and commit ₹3,000 crore for investment in India.

Foreign investors dump ₹60,847 cr. in April, devaluing rupee

This was the primary reason for the rupee depreciating further, touching a low of ₹95 a dollar before closing just short of that on Thursday

Ashokamithran T.
MUMBAI

Foreign investors sold ₹60,847 crore in stocks of Indian listed companies as of April 2026, continuing the two-year trend of capital outflow, data from the National Securities Depositories Ltd. (NSDL) show.

The outflow makes it the third in the first four months of the calendar year. There was a net inflow of ₹22,615 crore in February 2026. It was then followed by the highest ever outflow of more than ₹1.1 lakh crore in March 2026. The April sell-off is, however, much lower than the month before.

In the four months of calendar year 2026, ₹1.9 lakh crore worth of foreign money exited from Indian equities alone.

This is what had primarily led to the rupee touching a low of ₹95 a dollar before closing just short of that on Thursday. The rupee-dollar pair depreciated 5.5% between January 2026 and April 2026, backed by increasing import bills due to the West Asia crisis and the continued foreign money outflow from domestic capital markets.

“The interaction bet-



Money matters: The rupee-dollar pair depreciated 5.5% between January 2026 and April 2026, backed by increasing import bills. AFP

Continued FII outflow would mean the foreign exchange rate can touch ₹96 a dollar

ANINDYA BANERJEE,
Head of Commodity and Currency Research, Kotak Securities

ween portfolio outflows and exchange rate movements has exhibited self-reinforcing dynamics: rupee depreciation reduces dollar-denominated returns for foreign investors, prompting further outflows, which in turn exacerbates currency pressures. As India’s integration with global financial markets deepens, such episodes underscore the heightened sensitivity of capital flows to shifts in global risk sentiment,” the

Ministry of Finance observed in its monthly Economic Review.

A continued closure of the Strait of Hormuz would mean a heightened oil price and continued FII outflow would mean the foreign exchange rate can touch ₹96 a dollar. A break over that would lead to the rupee depreciating to ₹97 a dollar, said Anindya Banerjee, Head of Commodity and Currency Research, Kotak Securities. He further said that the rupee appreciating more than ₹94.8 is not likely without a “significant dip in oil prices.”

The outlook for rupee and the foreign money’s sensitivity to India’s foreign exchange rate may make their immediate return unlikely in the context of global geo-politics.

DIPAM gives nod for NLC arm’s listing; ₹4,000 cr. IPO in FY27

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

The Department of Investment and Public Asset Management (DIPAM) has given the green light for listing of Neyveli Lignite Corp. India’s (NLC India) renewable energy arm, NLC India Renewables (NIRL), a senior government official privy to the development told *The Hindu*.

The official further said that NIRL would be debuting on the bourses with its ₹4,000-crore IPO within the ongoing financial year.

“Last week, DIPAM had given their go-ahead for

NIRL’s debut on the bourses is premised on augmenting its current renewable energy capacity

the listing of NIRL. We expect the listing to be completed within FY 2027 itself,” the official stated.

As also confirmed by the senior official, the latest development implies that three of India’s State-owned mining companies – Bilaspur-headquartered South Eastern Coalfields Ltd. (SECL) and Sambalpur-headquartered Mahanadi Coalfields Ltd. (MCL),

– and now NIRL, are all set to hit Dalal Street within the ongoing financial year.

NLC India’s board had given its in-principle approval to list their renewable energy arm on January 12 this year.

This was in line with the targets laid out as per the National Monetisation Pipeline.

NIRL’s debut on the bourses is premised on further augmenting its current renewable energy capacity.

The renewable energy arm of NLC India is eyeing 10.11 GW of renewable capacity by 2030 and 32 GW by 2047.

Invest India facilitated grounding of \$6.1 bn projects in 2025-26

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Invest India, the national investment promotion and facilitation agency of the Government, has facilitated the grounding of 60 projects worth over \$6.1 billion during 2025-26, Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade of India (DPIIT) Secretary Amardeep Singh Bhatia said on Thursday.

Chemicals, pharmaceuticals and biotechnology, and food processing

sectors accounted for approximately 65% of the grounded investments, he added.

“The \$6.1 billion grounded by Invest India in FY 2025-26 reflects the strength of India’s regulatory environment and the depth of its economic transformation,” Mr. Bhatia said at a press briefing.

“DPIIT remains committed to further simplifying processes and ensuring that investments translate into jobs, innovation, and long-term value,” he said.

Fertiliser output steady despite West Asia crisis

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The government on Thursday said domestic urea production has reached 37.49 lakh tonnes in March-April, nearly matching last year’s levels despite the West Asia crisis, while securing 37 lakh tonnes of imported urea to meet the shortfall ahead of the Kharif season.

Total domestic fertiliser production stood at 62.37 lakh tonnes during March-April, while imports were at 15.39 lakh tonnes.

Soban Singh Jeena Government Institute of Medical Science & Research Almora

Near Vikas Bhawan, Pandeykhola, Almora, Distt-Almora-263601 (Uttarakhand)

E-mail - principal@gmcalmora@gmail.comhttp://www.ssjgimsralmora.org

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Letter No. 1826/GMCA-IG-1/Advertisement/2025-26Date:-30th April, 2026

Walk-In-Interview

A Walk In interview for various post of “Professor, Associate Professor & Assistant Professor” at Soban Singh Jeena Government Institute of Medical Science & Research Almora will be held on 07-05-2026 at 10:00 am on wards in “Office of the Principal, Soban Singh Jeena Government Institute of Medical Science & Research Almora”. Registration will be done on the day of interview till 1:00 PM only. The post will be filled on yearly renewal contract basis for a maximum period of 03 (three) years or till regular appointment are made. For further details please visit our website:-
http://www.ssjgimsralmora.org, www.medicaleducation.uk.gov.in & www.hnbumu.ac.in

Principal
SSJ Govt. IMSR Almora
Almora

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INDIAN MARITIME UNIVERSITY

(Central University, Govt. of India)

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Email: investorshelpdesk@sfl.co.in | Website: www.sundram.com

STATEMENT OF AUDITED STANDALONE AND CONSOLIDATED FINANCIAL RESULTS

FOR THE QUARTER AND YEAR ENDED MARCH 31, 2026

(₹ in Crores)

Sl. No.	Particulars	Standalone			Consolidated		
		Quarter ended	Year ended		Quarter ended	Year ended	
		31.03.2026	31.03.2025	31.03.2026	31.03.2026	31.03.2025	31.03.2026
(Audited)							
1	Total Revenue from Operations	1,502.05	1,353.99	5,542.06	1,693.30	1,530.59	6,288.82
2	Net Profit for the period (before tax and exceptional item)	203.06	162.10	749.63	212.80	164.25	801.18
3	Net Profit for the period (before tax)	231.86	174.60	767.41	212.80	164.25	788.07
4	Net Profit for the period (after tax)	179.88	134.37	580.38	161.36	124.49	592.85
5	Total Comprehensive Income for the period [Comprising Profit for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)]	160.91	123.58	576.54	162.15	109.39	633.76
6	Equity Share Capital (Face Value of Re 1 each fully paid up)	21.01	21.01	21.01	21.01	21.01	21.01
7	Earnings Per Share (EPS) (for continuing and discontinued operations) (Face value of Re 1/- each) (not annualised) (In Rs.)	8.56	6.39	27.62*	7.68	5.92	28.13*
	(a) Basic	8.56	6.39	27.62*	7.68	5.92	28.13*
	(b) Diluted						

* Annualised

Notes:

1 The above is an extract of the detailed format of the standalone and consolidated financial results filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the Financial Results are available on the Stock Exchange websites, www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com and on the Company’s website www.sundram.com. The full financial results can also be accessed by scanning the QR Code provided below.

2 The Statutory Auditors have carried out an audit for the year ended March 31, 2026 and have issued an unmodified report thereon.

Place : Chennai

Date : April 30, 2026

For Sundram Fasteners Limited

Suresh Krishna

Chairman

M CH-CH

Zelenskyy says he's seeking details of Putin's May 9 ceasefire proposal



In new salvo, Trump tells Merz to focus on Ukraine

Mr. Merz on Monday said Tehran was "humiliating" the U.S. in negotiations to end the U.S.-Israeli war on Iran.

EU says troop deployments in Europe is also 'in U.S. interest'



China FM says Taiwan is 'biggest risk point' in U.S.-China relations

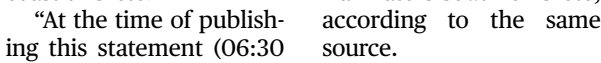


Mamdani calls on King Charles to return India's Koh-i-Noor diamond



Israel raids Gaza flotilla, 'kidnaps' crew members

“We don’t have the information for the other nationalities, but the boats were mixed in terms of na-



as "order," pointing lasers and semi-automatic assault weapons ordering participants to the front of the boats and to get on their hands and knees," the organisation had said.

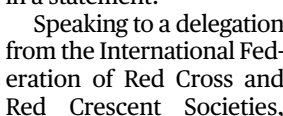
U.K. police probe stabbing attack on two Jewish men

and labeled the stabbing attack as an act of terrorism. Detectives are working to determine a motive and whether there is any



Police say 28 people have been arrested over those attacks, which did not cause any injuries. A handful have been charged and one teenager has been convicted after pleading guilty.

Lebanon says Israeli strikes killed 9 people



Lebanese state media reported a series of Israeli airstrikes across southern Lebanon on Thursday.

Myanmar coup-leader turned president orders Suu Kyi be moved to house arrest

It was not immediately clear where she will be moved, but a senior source from her dissolved Nation-

The official statement al-

As military chief, Min Aung Hlaing toppled Suu Kyi's elected government five years ago, detaining her on a host of charges which rights groups say were confected to sideline her.

Indian Institute of Science invites bids in two cover system through e-procurement platform <https://eprocure.gov.in>. Any specialised firms company registered under KPWD / CPWD/ railways/ MES/ central PSUs/ or any Government department of **Class I/Class A Electrical Contractors** are eligible to apply for the work of **"Providing 120KVA UPS and Replacement of Main LT Panels for Main Building at IISc Bangalore."** Estimated Cost of Project is **Rs.98,30,769/-**. Last date of receipt of application is **19th May 2026 at 15:30 Hrs.** Any other details can be obtained from the office of the Centre for Campus Management & Development, Indian Institute of Science, Bangalore on all working days or e-mail: office.ccmd@iisc.ac.in

 **भारतीय वानिकी अनुसंधान एवं शिक्षा परिषद**
(एन सी आर एफ ई) एवं जलवायु परिवर्तन में आधारी, भारत सरकार का एक स्वायत्त निकाय)
INDIAN COUNCIL OF FORESTRY RESEARCH AND EDUCATION
(An Autonomous Body of the Ministry of Environment,
Forest and Climate Change, Govt. of India)
प०आ० न्यू फॉरेस्ट, देहरादून – 248006 (उत्तराखण्ड)
P.O. New Forest, Dehra Dun – 248006 (Uttarakhand)

विज्ञप्ति संख्या 02/32-1/महाविदेशक/2026-मा.वा.अ.शि.प.
Advt. No. 02/32-1/Director General/2026-ICFRE

महाविदेशक, भारतीय वानिकी अनुसंधान एवं शिक्षा परिषद के पद को प्रतिनिधित्व के आधार पर सातवें सी.पी.सी. के वेतन मैट्रिक्स का स्तर-17 पर करने हेतु आवेदन आमंत्रित किए जाते हैं। आवेदन प्राप्त करने की अंतिम तिथि **01.06.2026** है तथा उपर्युक्त निकायों द्वारा समूह एवं लक्षदीपों के अस्थापितों के लिये **15.06.2026** होगी।

उपर्युक्त पद हेतु इच्छुक अभ्यर्थी मा०वा०आ०शि०प० की वेबसाइट <http://www.icfre.org> में दिये गये विस्तृत विज्ञापन के अनुसार आवेदन कर सकते हैं।

Applications are invited for filling up the post of Director General, Indian Council of Forestry Research and Education on deputation basis in pay Level -17 of 7th CPC Pay Matrix. The last date for receipt of application is 01.06.2026 and for candidates residing in Andaman Nicobar Islands and Lakshadweep the last date will be 15.06.2026.

The interested candidates may apply for the aforesaid post as per detailed advertisement availed on ICFRE website <http://www.icfre.org>

**सचिव, मा०वा०आ०शि०प०
Secretary, ICFRE**

STEPPING UP
It's about coming in and delivering when needed, says Holder



VIJAY SONEJI

I felt our energy was good. After the first couple of overs, everyone was a little edgy but credit to Kagiso Rabada for turning it around. Happy to contribute and help the team get over the line. More or less about coming in when needed, and delivering — GT's Jason Holder, the Player-of-the-Match against RCB.

PUNISHMENT
Royals captain Parag fined for vaping in the game against Kings



PTI

Rajasthan Royals captain Riyan Parag has been fined a quarter of his match fee for vaping in the dressing room. Images of Parag using an e-cigarette during Tuesday's match against Punjab Kings were broadcast live. E-cigarettes are banned in India under a 2019 law that prohibits their manufacture, import, sale and storage.

HUGE FACTOR
Starc's availability should help our team: DC bowling coach Munaf



FILE PHOTO: SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

Delhi Capitals bowling coach Munaf Patel said the availability of Mitchell Starc should help the team. "Our fast bowlers have struggled in the PowerPlay, and Starc could make a difference. He is our best bowler, so he should be playing, but I can't confirm whether he will play in the match against Rajasthan Royals".

WORDS OF ENCOURAGEMENT
'We need to remember Bumrah has been No. 1 for a good period'



PTI

When a cricketer is not doing well, we look at every single aspect. It is no different for Jasprit Bumrah. We need to remember what good he has done. He has not been up to the mark, but he has been No. 1 for Mumbai Indians and India for a good period of time — MI batting coach Kieron Pollard on the pacer's indifferent form.

Holder in the thick of it as GT gets the better of RCB

The all-rounder scalps two besides taking three catches to help the home team bowl out the defending champion for 155; Gill, Buttler and Tewatia shine for the Gujarat outfit in a tricky chase

IPL-19

N. Sudarshan
AHMEDABAD

It is difficult to cut an imposing figure in an arena as gigantic as the Narendra Modi Stadium. It is even tougher when more than 90,000 fans turn it into a raucous theatre where every creature can feel small and diminished.

But Jason Holder, the Barbados-born burly man of 6'7" frame, managed that Herculean feat with an all-round performance to carry Gujarat Titans to an important four-wicket victory over the in-form Royal Challengers Bengaluru in IPL 2026 on Thursday.

Diving effort
The 34-year-old bowled four first-rate overs (4-0-29-2), took three sharp-catches – including a diving effort at fine-leg to send back RCB skipper Rajat Patidar – and was involved in a calming 30-run stand for the sixth wicket with Rahul Tewatia (27 n.o., 17b, 4x4) as GT chased down 156 in the 16th over.

After typically classy knocks from Shubman Gill (43, 18b, 4x4, 3x6) and Jos Buttler (39, 19b, 2x4, 4x6), the GT middle-order had the soft-landing it needed to make its presence felt – 64 runs required from 75



Having a field day: Gill got Titans off to a blazing start. Arshad struck telling blows and got ample support from Rashid. Holder, too, made a big impression. VIJAY SONEJI

balls with seven wickets left. But it huffed and puffed, with Washington Sundar and Shahrulkh Khan both failing to anchor the pursuit, before Holder (12, 10b, 1x6) and Tewatia saved the day.

Earlier, put in to bat, RCB's all-conquering line-up was dismissed for the first time this season by a

wholesome Titans bowling effort.

Imperious Kohli
When the imperious Virat Kohli (28, 13b, 5x4, 1x6) hit Kagiso Rabada for five consecutive fours in the second over – a front-foot pull, a lofted shot over mid-off, a drive past backward point, a steer to third-

man and a drive through cover – RCB seemed pumped up.

But that was a high point the outfit rarely scaled for the rest of the innings. Jacob Bethell spooned a catch to short mid-wicket before Kohli was bounced out by Rabada.

Devdutt Padikkal (40,

24b, 5x4, 2x6) helped collect 59 from the PowerPlay, but RCB's hopes of using that as a launchpad never materialised as it was reduced to 126 for eight by the start of the 15th over.

All-rounder Venkatesh Iyer was even brought in as the Impact Player, but the left-hander could only manage a 15-ball 12.

From the last 32 balls, RCB scored just 29 runs, returns that seldom win T20 matches.

Next assignment

GT: May 3 vs. PBKS
Ahmedabad, 7.30 p.m.

RCB: May 7 vs. LSG
Lucknow, 7.30 p.m.

SCOREBOARD

ROYAL CHALLENGERS
Jacob Bethell c Rashid b Siraj 5 (5b, 1x4), Virat Kohli c Rashid b Rabada 28 (13b, 5x4, 1x6), Devdutt Padikkal b Rashid 40 (24b, 5x4, 2x6), Rajat Patidar c Holder b Arshad 19 (15b, 2x4, 1x6), Jitesh Sharma c Buttler b Holder 1 (3b), Tim David c Holder b Rashid 9 (6b, 1x6), Krunal Pandya c Holder b Arshad 4 (4b, 1x4), Romario Shephard c Sai Sudharsan b Holder 17 (15b, 2x6), Venkatesh Iyer (Impact Player for Bethell) c Sai Sudharsan b Arshad 12 (15b, 1x4), Bhuvneshwar Kumar (not out) 15 (15b, 2x4), Josh Hazlewood run out 0 (1b); Extras (lb-3, w-2): 5; Total (in 19.2 overs): 155.

FALL OF WICKETS
1-34 (Bethell, 2.4 overs), 2-35 (Kohli, 3.2), 3-79 (Patidar, 7.4), 4-80 (Jitesh, 8.1), 5-91 (David, 9.4), 6-96 (Krunal, 10.3), 7-126 (Padikkal, 13.6), 8-126 (Shepherd, 14.1), 9-155 (Venkatesh, 19.1).

TITANS BOWLING
Siraj 4-0-38-1, Rabada 4-0-44-1, Holder 4-0-29-2, Arshad 3.2-0-22-3, Rashid 4-0-19-2.

GUJARAT TITANS

Sai Sudharsan c Jitesh b Bhuvneshwar 6 (5b, 1x4), Shubman Gill c Kohli b Bhuvneshwar 43 (18b, 4x4, 3x6), Jos Buttler b Bhuvneshwar 39 (19b, 2x4, 4x6), Washington Sundar lbw b Shepherd 12 (12b, 1x6), Shahrulkh Khan c Hazlewood b Shepherd 8 (8b, 1x4), Rahul Tewatia (Impact Player for Siraj) (not out) 27 (17b, 4x4), Jason Holder c Padikkal b Suyash 12 (10b, 1x6), Rashid Khan (not out) 7 (6b, 1x4); Extras (w-4): 4; Total (for six wkts. in 15.5 overs): 158.

FALL OF WICKETS
1-42 (Sai Sudharsan, 2.6), 2-57 (Gill, 4.6), 3-92 (Buttler, 7.3), 4-109 (Shahrulkh, 10.1), 5-111 (Washington, 10.3), 6-141 (Holder, 13.5).

RCB BOWLING
Bhuvneshwar 4-0-28-3, Hazlewood 4-0-56-0, Suyash 3.5-0-44-1, Shepherd 4-0-30-2.

Toss: Gujarat Titans.

Player-of-the-Match: Holder.

Gujarat Titans won by four wickets with 25 deliveries remaining.

Points table

	M	W	L	NR	PTS	NRR
Punjab Kings	8	6	1	1	13	1.043
Royal Challengers	9	6	3	0	12	1.420
Sunrisers Hyderabad	9	6	3	0	12	0.832
Rajasthan Royals	9	6	3	0	12	0.617
Gujarat Titans	9	5	4	0	10	-0.192
Chennai Super Kings	8	3	5	0	6	-0.121
Delhi Capitals	8	3	5	0	6	-1.060
Kolkata Knight Riders	8	2	5	1	5	-0.751
Mumbai Indians	8	2	6	0	4	-0.784
Lucknow Super Giants	8	2	6	0	4	-1.106

Capitals need to turn it up against humming Royals

P.K. Ajith Kumar
JAIPUR

About 300 kms separate Delhi and Jaipur. The difference in quality of the cricket played by the franchises from the two northern Indian cities has been greater this IPL season.

While Rajasthan Royals is well placed to claim a berth in the playoffs, Delhi Capitals is lying in the bottom half. And after that nightmare of a match at home against Royal Challengers Bengaluru earlier this week, Axar Patel's men have to come up with a much better effort against Royals at the Sai Mansingh Stadium here on Friday.

Lightning usually doesn't strike twice, and Capitals' batting lineup is strong enough not to collapse for another score like 75. In just the previous match, K.L. Rahul alone had made more than double that total. Capitals made in excess of 260 against Punjab Kings, but still lost. When you cannot defend that big a score in one game and then get bowled out for an embarrassingly low total in the next, you certainly have to



Talk-time: Capitals skipper Axar catches up with RR's Shanaka and Bishnoi ahead of Friday's match. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

Today's match



Jaipur, 7.30 p.m.

HEAD-TO-HEAD

Played: 30

RR 15 | DC 15

PREVIOUS MEETING

Match tied

(DC won the Super Over), 2025

LIVE ON STAR SPORTS 1 & JIJOHTSTAR

do something. And time is running out. Delhi should be hoping for another major innings from Rahul, and from Nitish Rana, too. The two men had destroyed the Punjab Kings bowling in some style.

On the bowling front, there is some good news. Mitchell Starc is available

for the first time this season. The left-arm quick from Down Under will no doubt bolster the attack that received a setback through Lungi Ngidi's fall during the match against Punjab.

How Vaibhav Suryavashi greets Starc is definitely worth looking forward to. The prodigy's fearless batting has perhaps been the highlight of this IPL. Incidentally, he has hammered a century each in the two seasons he has figured in the league.

Suryavanshi's opening partner Yashasvi Jaiswal and Dhruv Jurel also provide impetus at the top of the order. As for bowling, you cannot hope for many better men than Jofra Archer to lead.

Players ought to maintain team culture: Sangakkara

P.K. Ajith Kumar
JAIPUR

While most things have gone right for Rajasthan Royals on the field this IPL, the same cannot be said about what has happened off it. First, there was the incident of team manager Romi Bhinder using his mobile phone in the dugout during the match against Royal Challengers Bengaluru.

Bhinder was fined ₹1 lakh and issued a warning by the BCCI's Anti-Corruption and Security Unit. Royals made the world's richest cricket body even richer on Thursday, with captain Riyan Parag being fined 25% of his match fee for vaping in the dressing room during the match against Punjab Kings.

Royals head coach Kumar Sangakkara admitted the controversies didn't really help them.

"Such controversies are no positives for the team and all I can say is that both issues have been addressed by the BCCI and the franchise," he said on the eve of RR's match against Delhi Capitals.



Royals head coach Sangakkara. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

"It is a reminder to the players that they have to maintain the team's culture."

About the match, the former Sri Lankan captain said he was expecting a tough challenge from the Capitals, despite their poor run of late. "And it looks like another good pitch out there," he said. "We don't expect anything less than the best out of DC."

Parag may not be in great form, but Sangakkara pointed out the importance of his knock in the victory against Punjab Kings. "His little innings (29 off 16 balls) shifted the momentum our way".

'MI not ready to throw in the towel yet'

Amol Karhadkar
MUMBAI

Kieron Pollard isn't ready to concede the IPL season just yet. Even as Mumbai Indians slumped to a sixth defeat in eight games, the batting coach struck a note of defiance, insisting the fight within the group remains intact.

"We need to play that complete game of cricket to win a match because it's getting difficult, the way the game is going," Pollard said after MI's loss to Sunrisers Hyderabad.

Impact Index

- 1 Mumbai Indians has used 22 players, the most by a team this season
- 5 Ricketton and Jacks are the fifth pair of MI openers this season. The last time it used as many was in 2016
- 5 The number of sixes Bumrah conceded against SRH, his joint worst after the five he was hit for in 2015 (vs. Delhi Daredevils)
- 32 The sixes count in the MI-SRH contest, the highest in an IPL game at Wankhede
- 54 Bumrah's costliest spell since 2021 (56 vs. CSK)

- 92 Runs conceded by MI in the PowerPlay, its joint most after the one against DC in 2024
- 100 SRH became the eighth team to register 100 IPL wins
- 123 Ricketton's is the highest individual score for MI in the league, bettering Jayasuriya's unbeaten 114 in 2008
- 243 MI's best total in the eighth team to register first
- 244 SRH's chase was the fourth highest in IPL history, and the highest at the Wankhede

Compiled by Anirudh Velamuri

Indian men pip Slovakia; women edge past Ukraine

WORLD TEAM TT

Press Trust of India
LONDON

The Indian men's team staged a spirited comeback to edge Slovakia 3-2 in a gripping Group 7 tie of the ITTF World team table tennis championships here on Wednesday.

India thus climbed to the top of the group table and strengthened its chances of advancing.

In the women's section, India rose to the occasion, pipping Ukraine 3-2, to go atop Group 6.

The results:
Men: India bt Slovakia 3-2 (Manush Shah lost to Lubomir Pistek 8-11, 11-5, 11-8, 5-11, 6-11; Manav Thakkar bt Jakub Zelinka 11-6, 11-8, 11-6; Harmet Desai lost to Wang Yang 14-16, 5-11, 9-11; Manav bt Pistek 11-3, 11-3, 11-3; Manush bt Zelinka 11-8, 11-8, 11-7).

Women: India 3 bt Ukraine 2 (Manika Batra bt Tetyana Bilenko 11-9, 7-11, 11-6, 11-5; Yashaswini Ghorpade lost to Margaryta Pesotska 11-7, 11-8, 1-11, 9-11, 9-11; Diya Chitale bt Veronika Matiuina 11-6, 11-8, 11-6; Manika lost to Pesotska 9-11, 11-5, 8-11, 6-11; Yashaswini bt Bilenko 11-7, 11-9, 9-11, 11-7).

R. Kaushik

To say that IPL 2026, which has sauntered past the halfway stage of the league phase, has been dominated by the bat will be a massive understatement. The first 42 matches, including Gujarat Titans' four-wicket victory over Royal Challengers Bengaluru in Ahmedabad on Thursday night, have produced 35 scores of 200 and more, 10 of those coming in successful chases.

Last Saturday, Punjab Kings topped their own previous mark of 262 by mounting the highest successful chase in all 20-over cricket, hunting down Delhi Capitals' 264 for two with so much to spare. Centuries have started to come thick and fast – Sanju Samson alone has two of them – and 15-ball fifties no longer hold the same wonderment and awe even when they cascade from the blade of a 15-year-old. After all, Vaibhav Suryavanshi has three of those this season, delivered with nonchalance and chutzpah as he has taken on and destroyed some of the best in the business, among them Jasprit Bumrah, Josh Hazlewood and Pat Cummins.

Bumrah has had a tournament to forget thus far, his travails mirroring those of his team's. Five-time former champions Mumbai are just off the foot of the table, Wednesday's six-wicket defeat by SRH their sixth loss in eight outings. Bumrah, astonishingly, has taken a mere two wickets from 30 overs. Just sit back for a second and allow that to sink in – a wicket every 90 deliveries for arguably the greatest all-format bowler of all time. We are talking about a champion who has 185 IPL wickets (19.01 balls per scalp) and 121 wickets from 95 T20Is (SR: 16.6). The Player-of-the-Tournament when India won the T20 World Cup in 2024, the Player-of-the-Final when they retained that crown in Ahmedabad this March. Bumrah hasn't been at his best, perhaps overreaching with every passing wicketless outing, of which there have been six, and has been mercilessly punished.

He has gone at 8.80 runs per over, perfectly acceptable for almost everyone else but somehow off when it comes to Bumrah, whose career T20 economy (in 278 matches) is a frugal 6.96 and whose T20I economy is even more impressive, at 6.51 runs per over.

What must irk Bumrah more is that his decidedly sub-par returns have come in a tournament where, around the batting carnage, pace bowlers, his comrades in arms, have tasted reasonable success – reasonable being a relative term, given the boundary-fest. Yuzvendra Chahal, the pixie leg-spinner, is the leading wicket-taker in IPL history; four of the top five most prolific IPL bowlers are all spinners (Sunil Narine, Piyush Chawla and R. Ashwin being the other three), the domination of spin only broken by Bhuvneshwar Kumar, who is second behind Chahal (228) with 215 victims. But this season, the balance is unquestionably skewed towards the faster bowlers, with spinners primarily forced to play second fiddle. Last season, even though they failed to reach the final, Gujarat Titans boasted the Purple Cap winner in Prasidh Krishna (25 wickets), but he was run very close by Noor Ahmad (24), the left-arm wrist-spinner, even though Chennai Super Kings took home the wooden spoon. Keeping Noor spinning company among the ten highest wicket-takers were Sai Kishore (19), Varun Chakaravathy and Krunal Pandya (17 apiece). This year, Noor has picked up seven wickets from eight matches, Varun has seven from six and, shockingly, Tamil Nadu left-arm spinner and State skipper Sai Kishore hasn't played a single game.

There are only two spinners in the top 10 – Leggie Ravi Bishnoi (11) and Noor's Afghanistan colleague A.M. Ghazanfar (10), slotting in at eighth and ninth places respectively. Otherwise, the leaderboard is replete with fast bowlers, who have brought their skill and craft and guile and nous and experience into play even when the odds have been stacked against them. The seasoned Bhuvneshwar, now 36, holds the Purple Cap with 17 wickets while Eshan Malinga, the Sri Lankan who has been such an influential figure in SRH's march to the third position, is next with 15. Then come the fiery Jofra Archer and Anshul Kamboj with 14 apiece. Prince Yadav, Prasidh and Mohsin Khan round off the top 10 in the company of Kagiso Rabada, the South African who topped 150 kmph in all six deliveries of an over against Royal Challengers Bengaluru last week and is enjoying himself in a Gujarat attack that, apart from Prasidh, includes Mohammed Siraj too.

Hunting in pairs

It is said of fast bowlers that they hunt in pairs, and this edition has illustrated that perfectly. No one has exemplified that better than Bhuvneshwar and Josh

The pace revolution in the IPL

The wicket-takers' leaderboard is replete with fast bowlers, who have brought their skill and craft and experience into play even when the odds have been stacked against them



Training sessions tend to be more feel-good outings for the batters while the bowlers bowl well within themselves for the most part, saving their best for the 24 deliveries in a match scenario

Hazlewood, who have been the standout performers for RCB, primarily in the PowerPlay. At the Arun Jaitley Stadium in the national capital on Monday, they ran amok against Delhi Capitals who, in their previous outing, had stacked up 264. Each of them took three wickets apiece within their first two overs, reducing Delhi to a scarcely believable 8 for 6. And they did so not with any great trickery but by sticking to the tried and the tested, bowling an almost Test-match line and length to cut a swathe through a shell-shocked top order.

Bhuvneshwar produced the perfect yorker off the second ball of the contest to knock out debutant Sahil Parakh's middle pole, the start of undiluted mayhem. It wasn't the first time in the season that the two pacers with a combined age of 71 left a lasting impression. Despite missing RCB's opening two games, Hazlewood has taken eight wickets to back up Bhuvneshwar's incisiveness. Their allies have been seam and swing, and hitting the hard lengths as opposed to the express pace with which Archer and his Rajasthan Royals colleague Nandre Burger have terrorised batters.

Archer has taken a wicket with the first ball of the innings thrice already – it should have been four had Dhruv Jurel behind the stumps not dropped a sitter offered by Priyansh Arya – and has brooked careful watching every time he has gracefully loped in and let the ball go. More than anyone else, he has hit what the pundits call the 'hard' length, from where it is impossible to tee off for even the more accomplished. That explains his impressive economy of 8.27, which too has been trumped by Bhuvneshwar (7.54).

These are bowlers who bowl in the most demanding phases of the match – in the first six overs, when only two fielders are permitted beyond the 30-yard circle, and towards the final stages when every ball is like a free hit.

That they have been able to hold their own, and at times dominate the batters, is tribute to both their immense skills and their strength of character and conviction. They have kept pace with the demands of the modern game by expanding their repertoire and constantly adding new tricks to their armoury, reiterating that the process of learning never stops.

While most of the fast bowlers in the leading wicket-takers' list are seasoned internationals, Prince doesn't fall in that category. Before this season, the 24-year-old had played only 21 T20 games, six of them last season for Lucknow Super Giants when he only picked up three wickets. Prince had come into prominence with his exploits in the Delhi Premier League and was procured by LSG for a modest ₹30 lakh at the mega auction towards the end of 2024.

That seems like a bargain buy right now. Prince can work up reasonable pace – in the last 130s – and has a multitude of

variations. Until he went wicketless against Kolkata Knight Riders on Sunday, he had tasted at least one success in each of the previous seven fixtures. His economy is a commendable 8.06, which is made even more admirable by the fact that LSG are rock-bottom with just two wins from eight games and with a net run-rate of -1.106.

Dale Steyn, the great South African paceman who is revelling in his current avatar as a wonderful analyst and reader of the game, had an interesting take while explaining the successes of the fast bowlers, pointing out that batters today don't practice enough against this kind of bowling. "Watching Bhuvu, Hazlewood, throw KG and Archer in there too, there's a genuine fear from batters not because they scared, but they know exactly where these greats are going to bowl but don't practice enough in that area to have answers," Steyn, who took 97 IPL wickets in 95 matches, said on X. "The fear is technical skill, too deep into the tournament to change now, watch these bowlers continue to dominate. It's called a HARD length for a reason..."

Batters' problems

Clearly, Steyn doesn't need any validation, but those who have watched teams practice before matches can easily relate to what he is saying. At net sessions in the lead-up to and on the evening before a game, balls fly everywhere at training and even a second's lack of focus – from those not batting and the few who have been able to secure entry to watch practice from the stands – can lead to disastrous consequences. There is a concerted effort to hone range-hitting abilities; there is an almost unwritten competition with regard to who can smite the ball the longest, who can put the ball on the roof. Not too many batters are confronted with the indeterminate-length balls aimed at the body that preclude freeing of the arms and therefore the resultant towering blows. Training sessions tend to be more feel-good outings for the batters while the bowlers bowl well within themselves for the most part, saving their best for the 24 deliveries in a match scenario.

On flat tracks where the ball comes evenly on to the bat and which take a lot of pace off the ball once it bounces, it is still possible to make late improvisations but when there is a bit of life, like there has been at Lucknow's Ekana International Stadium, there is nowhere for the batters to hide. As the tournament wears on, it is likely that the pitches will get a little tired and there won't be as much for the Bhuvneshwars and the Hazlewoods, the Archers and the Rabadas, to work with. But then, given how skilled they are, they have already shown that they don't need too much extraneous assistance, haven't they?

THE GIST

Bumrah has had a tournament to forget thus far, his travails mirroring those of his team's. Five-time former champions Mumbai are just off the foot of the table

It is said of fast bowlers that they hunt in pairs, and this edition has illustrated that perfectly. No one has exemplified that better than Bhuvneshwar and Josh Hazlewood, who have been the standout performers for RCB

While most of the fast bowlers in the leading wicket-takers' list are seasoned internationals, Prince doesn't fall in that category. His economy is a commendable 8.06, which is made even more admirable by the fact that LSG are rock-bottom



How residential segregation shapes public health access in India

Neighbourhoods with higher concentrations of Dalit and Muslim communities are significantly less likely to have schools, health centres, piped water, sanitation, or electricity; this means limited access to care, as well as higher risks of disease, delayed treatment, and worse health outcomes

Christianez Ratna Kiruba

As a child travelling to her grandparents' home, Nancy Angeline remembers getting off at a bus stop that was never quite her destination.

The bus would halt at Valliyur—a village with paved roads, shops, a school, and a health centre. From there, she walked in near darkness, under starlight, past the last row of houses and across an invisible boundary into her grandparents' home.

Magizhchipuram, where they lived, was a Dalit Christian settlement — physically separated from the village, neglected, and socially excluded. The line drawn was not geographical; it was caste.

Only decades later, as a community medicine doctor, did she find a name for it: residential segregation. With it came a sharper realisation — this separation shaped not just where people lived, but who could access healthcare.

What Nancy experienced reflects a bigger, largely invisible pattern.

A working paper, 'Residential Segregation and Unequal Access to Local Public Services in India', by Sam Asher et al, analysing over 15 lakh neighbourhoods, finds high levels of segregation among Muslims and Scheduled Castes — closely tied to unequal access to basic services.

In urban areas, segregation indices range from 0.52 for Muslims to 0.59 for Scheduled Castes — meaning over half would need to relocate for full integration. Nearly one in four urban Muslims lives in neighbourhoods that are more than 80% Muslim.

Neighbourhoods with higher concentrations of these communities are significantly less likely to have schools, health centres, piped water, sanitation, or electricity. These disparities are often invisible at district or State levels, where policy is made, but stark at the neighbourhood level — clusters of just a few hundred households. Inequality in India is not only widespread; it is spatially organised and hidden in plain sight.

During her community medicine training, Nancy returned to villages as a researcher. "In many places, the Anganwadi, school, and primary health centre would all be in the main village — and inaccessible to those in Dalit settlements," she says.

Healthcare infrastructure is typically placed based on centrality and connectivity — locations with roads, buses, and ambulance access. But in caste-segregated geographies, these "central" points are usually dominant caste areas, leaving Dalit settlements excluded by default.

Health camps, too, are often held in dominant caste spaces — temples, central squares, community halls — where Dalit residents may not be allowed or, feel safe entering. Village health committees, meant to guide local planning, are frequently dominated by upper-caste men, shaping where these services are placed.

Nancy recalls a case that continues to stay with her from her work in a village. A child with severe malnutrition lived in a Dalit settlement. When she urged the mother to take the child to the Anganwadi



Living on the margins: In urban areas, segregation indices range from 0.52 for Muslims to 0.59 for Scheduled Castes — meaning over half would need to relocate for full integration. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

to access free meals, the response was not what she expected. "It was not that she did not want care," Nancy says. "She told me it was unsafe for her to go to that part of the village as a Dalit woman. Every time she went, she was humiliated." The mother's refusal, she realised, was not a failure of awareness or intent — but of dignity.

Dynamics across India

These dynamics extend beyond Tamil Nadu. Tanya Tanisha Mohanty, an English literature scholar who has done field work on women in villages in Odisha, describes how social identity continues to shape not just where people live, but also who they can ask for care or support from.

In one cluster of villages near Patia, she recalls, a single clinic served multiple surrounding settlements. Yet since the clinic was located within an upper-caste area, access to it was regulated. Dalit residents could only visit on specific days and within fixed hours and these restrictions were even displayed on the clinic board.

"These timings were set so that upper-caste residents would not be offended," she says. "If you had an emergency outside that window, you simply could not go."

For those needing urgent care — particularly pregnant women or those with acute conditions — this effectively placed healthcare out of reach.

Access to medicines, too, followed informal hierarchies. In some cases, intermediaries would procure medicines from nearby towns, but distribution was uneven or came at higher costs.

These patterns are not limited to caste. In urban and peri-urban India, Muslim-majority neighbourhoods often face similar spatial exclusion.

Shakeeb Ahmed Khan, a physiotherapist who has worked extensively in Muslim-majority areas,

Neighbourhoods with fewer services, poorer infrastructure, and limited access to care face higher risks of disease, delayed treatment, and worse health outcomes

recalls supervisors telling him these neighbourhoods would have higher disability due to consanguineous marriages — a reflection of entrenched bias against the Muslim community. But prevalence data did not support these assumptions.

"People who deliver healthcare to these areas also carry their biases and assumptions with them," he says.

In parts of Nagpur, he notes, Muslim-dominated areas had weaker infrastructure, fewer amenities, and limited services. Healthcare access followed similar lines. Health centres in marginalised areas were often understaffed or non-functional, forcing residents to travel farther for care, while centres in more affluent areas were better resourced.

"There was an implicit understanding that if you want better care, you would go to a PHC in a better neighborhood," he says. Over time, he says, many residents adapt. "People focus on work and on earning more to access private facilities. They also try to get what they can, within what is available."

These implications for public health are profound. Neighbourhoods with fewer services, poorer infrastructure, and limited access to care face higher risks of disease, delayed treatment, and worse health outcomes.

Despite decades of welfare programmes, Indian public policy has rarely treated residential segregation as a driver of inequality. Most interventions assume services within a village or district

are equally accessible. In reality, access depends on where services are located — and who can enter those spaces. There have been moments of recognition. The Sachar Committee Report noted that many Muslim communities live in segregated, under-serviced localities. But such insights have not translated into policy frameworks that account for segregation itself.

Policy in practice

These patterns are also shaped — and at times reinforced — by policy.

Laws such as the Gujarat Disturbed Areas Act restrict property transactions in notified areas. Initially introduced to prevent distress sales of property in areas of sectarian violence, it is now used to make it difficult for Muslims to buy homes in Hindu-majority neighbourhoods, thereby deepening segregation. Rajasthan has seen similar moves through administrative and policy directions. In Assam, although no equivalent legislation exists, a series of eviction drives and administrative controls over land have reshaped settlement patterns, disproportionately affecting minority communities.

Together, these measures risk formalising existing divides, contributing to the ghettoisation of minority communities, a trend that accelerated over the past decade, as noted by many researchers.

Large structural changes are needed to dismantle geography as a barrier for healthcare delivery. In the meantime, however, the public health system must recognise the existence of these barriers at the level of neighbourhoods and work on solutions to actively redistribute care to reach those kept at the margins.

(Dr. Christianez Ratna Kiruba is an internal medicine doctor, with a passion for patient rights advocacy. christianezdennis@gmail.com)

THE GIST

A working paper analysing over 15 lakh neighbourhoods, finds high levels of segregation among Muslims and Scheduled Castes — closely tied to unequal access to basic services

Healthcare infrastructure is typically placed based on centrality and connectivity — locations with roads, buses, and ambulance access. But in caste-segregated geographies, these "central" points are usually dominant caste areas, leaving Dalit settlements excluded by default

Large structural changes are needed to dismantle geography as a barrier for healthcare delivery. In the meantime, however, the public health system must recognise the existence of these barriers at the level of neighbourhoods and work on solutions

THE HEALTH QUIZ

Over 90% of people around the world will experience a headache at some point in their lives. How much do you know about them? Here is a quiz on everything related to headaches

Zubeda Hamid

QUESTION 1

What is the most common type of headache condition?

- a) Nicotine headache
- b) Sinus headache
- c) Tension-type headache
- d) Migraine

QUESTION 2

What do you call a type of brief, severe, frequently recurring headache, focused on one side of the head or around one eye? They are relatively uncommon affecting fewer than 1 in 1000 adults.

QUESTION 3

Which type of headache ranks third in accounting for overall neurological disease burden as

measured by age-standardised disability-adjusted life years?

QUESTION 4

Migraines are hereditary. Is this statement true or false.

QUESTION 5

Rebound headache is a commonly-used term for a headache due to the overuse of _____

QUESTION 6

What food, popularly known as 'food of the Gods' is believed to trigger migraine in some people?

QUESTION 7

Mucus building up in your _____ can cause a headache, where you face hurts.

Answers to previous edition's quiz:

1. Repeated untreated middle ear infections in childhood can lead to long-term hearing problems. True or False. **Ans: True**
 2. A persistent ringing or buzzing sound in the ears without an external source is called _____. **Ans: Tinnitus**
 3. A routine test used to check a person's hearing ability? **Ans: Audiometry**
 4. Name one sign that may suggest a child has hearing difficulty. **Ans: Frequently asking for repetition/Turning one ear toward the speaker**
 5. Hearing loss that develops after long-term exposure to loud sounds is called _____. **Ans: Conductive**
- Visual: Injury to which inner ear structure would most directly impair the ear's ability to convert sound vibrations into signals transmitted to the brain? **Ans: The cochlea**

Winner: Prem raj P.

Visual question: It is a popular theory that the English author in this image suffered from migraines and that influenced his dream-like, size-distorted characters in a famous children's novel. Name the author **WIKIMEDIA COMMONS**



Please send in your answers to health@thehindu.co.in

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Dilapidated school buildings demolished in Dehradun

56 The Dehradun district administration has demolished 56 dilapidated school buildings to ensure the safety of students and eight more are likely to be razed within a month, officials said on Thursday. A total of 64 condemned school buildings were identified. PTI

Percentage increase in India's marine fish catch in 2025

3 in per cent. India's marine fish production in 2025 rose by 3% to 35.7 lakh tonnes compared to the previous year, ICAR-CMFRI on Thursday said. According to an assessment by the ICAR-Central Marine Fisheries Research Institute, Tamil Nadu emerged as the top marine fish-producing State. PTI

Percentage growth of Taiwan's economy in the first quarter

13.70 in per cent. Taiwan's economy saw double-digit growth in the first three months of 2026 thanks to robust demand for artificial intelligence technology, data showed Thursday, despite concerns over the West Asia crisis. AFP

Number of Gaza activists 'kidnapped' by Israel

211 Organisers of a Gaza-bound aid flotilla said Israel's army had "kidnapped" 211 activists in a raid in international waters off Greece. Helene Coron, a spokeswoman for the Global Sumud France, that the operation had taken place near the island of Crete. AFP

Number of registered users on PhonePe as of April 29

700 in million. PhonePe announced that it has crossed the milestone of 700 million (70 crore) registered users on as of April 29. This highlights PhonePe's population-scale reach in India and the breadth of its digital platform offerings. PTI
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How is the next UN chief being chosen?

Why is the role of Secretary-General important? Who are the candidates? What factors shape the choice? Why does this election matter now? What are the candidates' campaign priorities? What happens next?

EXPLAINER

Raja Karthikeya

The story so far:

The election of the next UN Secretary-General is underway. On April 21-22, four candidates – two women and two men – pitched their records of public service and leadership to the UN General Assembly in “informal, interactive dialogues”.

Why is the role of Secretary-General important?

The UN Charter defines the Secretary-General as the UN's Chief Administrative Officer, who oversees the work of the UN Secretariat and fulfils “any other functions and duties entrusted” to them by the organisation's principal organs, including the General Assembly, the Security Council, and the Economic and Social Council. The Secretary-General also has the mandate to bring to the Security Council's attention any issue that threatens global peace and security.

Where needed, the Secretary-General has the authority to appoint “Personal Envoys” (as Antonio Guterres has now done for the current West Asia conflict).

Often described as the world's “chief diplomat,” the Secretary-General is the face and voice of the UN, speaking as the world's conscience on issues ranging from the arms race in space and climate change to persistent inequality that hampers economic growth.

How is the Secretary-General elected?

The UN Charter states that the Secretary-General is appointed by the General Assembly on the recommendation of the Security Council. This means that the Permanent Members of the Security Council – China, France, Russia, the U.K., and the U.S. – have a significant say in who gets elected.

What considerations play a role?

While the term of a Secretary-General is



Often described as the world's ‘chief diplomat,’ the Secretary-General is the voice of the UN. REUTERS

technically “discretionary,” incumbents have, since 1981, voluntarily limited themselves to two terms. By custom, the post rotates among five regions of the world: Africa, Asia, Eastern Europe, Western Europe, and Latin America and the Caribbean. This is the turn of the latter. Within the region, there are dynamics at play, with Spanish-speaking Latin American countries and English-speaking Caribbean nations supporting different candidates.

Who are the candidates?

The four candidates now officially in the race are: Michelle Bachelet, former President of Chile and former UN High Commissioner for Human Rights; Macky Sall, former President of Senegal; Rafael Grossi, Head of the International Atomic Energy Agency; and Rebecca Grynspan, Head of the UN Conference on Trade and Development.

Why is this election crucial?

Eighty years after its founding, the UN is facing a deep financial and political crisis. The Secretariat relies on mandatory “assessed contributions” collected from member states. Still, non-payment, partial payment, and delay in payment of dues by

leading contributors have triggered an unprecedented financial situation.

The Security Council is paralysed by acrimony and persistent vetoes by the permanent members. The UN is also struggling to mobilise funds and troops for missions in places such as Haiti, and with host country relations in cases such as in Mali, where the UN mission was forced to withdraw.

Over the past decade, the UN played a key role in responding to the COVID-19 pandemic, advancing climate action through the Paris Agreement, and promoting sustainable development via the 2030 Agenda. However, recent conflicts in Gaza, Lebanon, Sudan, Ukraine, and Iran have raised questions about its ability to prevent war – a central idea of the UN Charter. There are increasing calls for the UN to “return to basics” by focusing more on conflict resolution. The Sustainable Development Goals are now universal markers of developmental progress but there is rising concern that only 18% of the targets are on track to be met by 2030. Meanwhile, the humanitarian system is under severe strain due to multiple conflicts, intensifying disasters, and pressures on international humanitarian law. The next

Secretary-General will have the unenviable task of not just administering, but rejuvenating the organisation.

What are the candidates' campaign priorities?

During their interactions with the General Assembly, Ms. Bachelet, Ms. Grynspan, and Mr. Sall all emphasised preventive diplomacy – the UN term for preventing conflicts through adroit behind-the-scenes parley with the stakeholders to the conflict. However, their approaches differ. Ms. Bachelet prioritised field presence, while Ms. Grynspan focused on merging the UN's work in the prevention of conflict with its work on human rights. Ms. Grynspan was arguably the most vocal on UN reform, proposing restructuring the Secretary-General's office within the first 100 days if elected. Among areas for priority action, Ms. Bachelet highlighted climate, Mr. Sall highlighted migration, and Mr. Grossi highlighted UN-World Bank relations. Ms. Grynspan stressed the need to protect least-developed nations from funding cuts.

All candidates committed to gender parity, while Ms. Bachelet emphasised improving geographic diversity within the UN workforce, a longstanding demand of developing countries. On the stasis in the Security Council, Ms. Grynspan and Mr. Sall said they would publicly call out permanent members of the council who violate international law, while Mr. Grossi promised to uphold the UN Charter. Ms. Bachelet said she will use the Secretary-General's office to build political viability for Security Council reform.

What happens next?

In the next phase, the Security Council will hold closed-door deliberations and straw polls before recommending a candidate to the General Assembly around October. Once the latter confirms the choice through a simple majority vote, the new Secretary-General will take office on January 1, 2027.

(Raja Karthikeya is a former international civil servant)

THE GIST

▼ The UN is facing a deep financial and political crisis, with Security Council paralysis, funding shortfalls, and rising global conflicts.

▼ The next Secretary-General will have the task of rejuvenating the organisation, focusing on conflict prevention, reform, and advancing sustainable development goals.

What happened to Komagata Maru passengers in 1914?

Why was the Komagata Maru denied entry into Canada? What happened to the passengers?

Prathmesh Kher

The story so far:

In the spring of 1914, a Japanese steamship called the Komagata Maru sailed from Hong Kong toward Vancouver, British Columbia, carrying 376 passengers: 340 Sikhs, 24 Muslims, and 12 Hindus from Punjab in British India. They were British subjects hoping to build new lives in Canada. What awaited them was a two-month standoff in the harbour, a brutal denouement on the docks of Calcutta, and a place in the history of both India's anti-colonial movement and Canada's long reckoning with its own past. The episode was recently mentioned by singer Diljit Dosanjh on *The Tonight Show Starring Jimmy Fallon*.

Why was Punjab central to events leading up to the voyage?

By 1914, Punjab had become the primary recruiting ground for the British Indian Army. The British had cultivated Punjab

as a loyal province populated by a “martial race,” but the relationship was both lopsided and extractive. Rapid agricultural growth combined with easy credit had created a crisis of rural indebtedness, and epidemics of malaria and plague in the early 1900s pushed families toward emigration as the only way out.

Among those who left were the founders of the Ghadar movement, established in 1913 among expatriate Punjabis on the U.S. West Coast, dedicated to the armed overthrow of British rule in India.

The Komagata Maru voyage was freighted with this politics from the start. Ghadar activists boarded the ship in Yokohama, delivering lectures and distributing anti-colonial literature, and British intelligence was watching closely.

What led to the standoff?

The voyage was organised by Gurdit Singh, a Punjabi entrepreneur based in Singapore, who chartered the ship

specifically to challenge Canada's exclusionary laws. Canada had enacted a “continuous journey regulation” in 1908, barring entry to anyone who had not travelled by a single unbroken journey from their country of birth, while also pressuring shipping companies not to sell direct tickets from India.

When the ship arrived at Vancouver's Burrard Inlet on May 23, 1914, immigration officials refused to let it dock. Prime Minister Robert Borden kept the ship anchored offshore, cutting off communication and stalling proceedings. The local South Asian community raised over \$20,000 to take over the ship's charter and hired a lawyer to bring a test case, but the British Columbia Court of Appeal unanimously upheld the discriminatory laws. Officials then withheld food and water. On July 19, an armed police force of 150 men attempted to board the ship; the passengers fought them off. Borden dispatched a naval cruiser. Only 22 passengers, mostly those who could prove prior Canadian

residence, were ultimately permitted to disembark. The ship departed under escort on July 23. British colonial authorities, suspicious of the passengers' politics, refused to let the ship dock in Hong Kong or Singapore. When it finally anchored near Calcutta in late September, police tried to force the exhausted passengers onto trains bound for Punjab. They refused, marched toward the city, and were fired upon. Twenty passengers were killed; many more were imprisoned. Gurdit Singh evaded capture for years before surrendering in 1920 and serving five years in prison.

What happened when the ship returned to India?

In the aftermath, the Ghadar movement surged in recruitment. Some members returned to Punjab in 1915 to attempt an armed uprising, which failed due to informers and mass arrests. Dozens were sent to the gallows. But the movement's martyrs became folklore.

Canada was slow to acknowledge what it had done. An apology delivered at a community festival by Prime Minister Stephen Harper in 2008 was rejected by many as insufficient. It took until 2016 for Prime Minister Justin Trudeau to deliver a formal apology on the floor of the House of Commons. The Komagata Maru remains a sharp demonstration of what colonial subjects had long understood: that the British Empire's promises of equal subjecthood were never meant for everyone.

THE GIST

▼ The Komagata Maru carried 376 British subjects from Punjab but was denied entry into Canada under the “continuous journey” regulation, leading to a two-month standoff in Vancouver harbour.

▼ On returning to India, the passengers faced police firing near Calcutta, killing 20 people.

